

Laurentius saga

Sagas of Icelanders

Norse Sagas

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THE LIFE OF LAURENCE, BISHOP OF HÔLAR

1

WHEN AT THE helm of God's Church Universal was the Apostolic Father Urban, fourth of his name, and Pope in Rome; and when Lord Hâkon, archbishop of Nidards church, and Jorund Thorsteinsson, bishop of the church of Holar, were mighty in the northern quarter of Iceland; and when that gracious lord, our lord the King Magnus Hâkonarson, ruled in Norway with the temporal rod; — this history, which with God's help we will begin, was first written, to delight and fleet the time of good men, and for knowledge withal and for edifying; concerning Lord Laurence, bishop at Holar, of excellent memory. He himself admonished me to keep in mind whatsoever he related about the course of his life before he was bishop at Holar. But his life afterwards was well known to one, who was night and day in his service and lodging while he was bishop in Iceland until he died. Here also much is gathered together, after the notices of the annals that seem best informed, about divers events that befell in divers countries.

2

Likewise are put in many things about bishops and other great men of the world who lived at the time of this history. And though there be some lost labour in compiling such things as may be shown forth and declared in this account, yet it is worse to give ear or heed to pagan histories. Now God give well-being of life and soul to whoso hearken with patience and loving-kindness; but whoso with malice and leasing reject contemptuously, may such receive their reward!

3

2. The father of Bishop Laurence, by name Kálf, was the son of the sister of a decent clerk, Sir Thórarin, known as 'Keg,' who held a good living at Vellir in Svarfadar-dale. Sir Thórarin was a fine scholar, and the usefulest of men at letters or transcribing work; many books, which he wrote out for Hólar church and likewise for his own at Vellir,

are still to be seen. Much goods to his poor kindred Sir Thórarin gave, and much alms he sunk in estates over Svarfadar- dale and elsewhere also, though some of them be held now in no account and slighted in oblivion. Laurence' mother was named Thorgrima, daughter of Einar; she, and thus Laurence, traced descent to a priest called Illugi, otherwise Hilarius; of whom it is told, in the Life of John the bishop of Hólar, how he and he only came forward to give up his landed inheritance at Hólar in Hjalta-dale, so that holy Bishop John might there set up the bishopric which has remained ever since. This same Hilarius went later to Breidabólstað in Vestrhóp, and there his dead body lies, but his soul is with God in bliss everlasting. Also it befell afterwards, when Laurence was worst beset by his foes and stript of all his goods, that Sir Haflidi, his dearest friend, gave this good woman provision in all things to the day of her death, and her body also lies in the aforesaid church at Breidabólstað; and to the church there Laurence, gave the goodliest mass-vestments in the place, for her soul's sake. Many dreams worthy of note came to this Thorgrima, when she was great with the child Laurence, and one of them we will set down.

4

She dreamed that she had come to Hólar church on some high-day, when there was a great crowd to the place; and it seemed to her that she could not get in through the church door for the press of people. 'Then a notablelooking man appeared to come out of the church and take her by the hand; and he led her in before the high altar. And this man delivered into her right hand something hard in a linen kerchief, thus speaking to her: —

5

'This is to be thine, Thorgrima, and thou shalt keep it heedfully.' Then this man turned from her, and she thought she showed this treasure to Sir Thórarin her kinsman at Vellir, and undid the kerchief; and there lay a great bishop's signet with the image of a bishop graven upon it; this, as it seemed, she kept afterwards. And the thing appeared of fair omen.

6

3. When Kálf and Thorgrima dwelt in Efra-Ás in Hjalta-dale, Thorgrima was long past her time to be delivered; and Sir Thórarin asked Thorgrima, being his nephew's wife, to his home at Vellir. A heaviness came upon her so that she could scarce bear up, and before St. Laurence' Day she fell ill, lay on the floor, and could not be delivered; many prayers were said over her, but there was no change in her for the better. Before mass on St. Laurence' Day Sir Thorarin went in to her, and chanted over her, and by God's grace she bore a man-child; but in this child no man saw a sign of life. Then Sir Thorarin vowed that this boy should be called Laurence, and that if St. Laurence vouchsafed life to this boy, he should all his life after keep a water-fast before St. Laurence' Day, if he had years and health for it. And when this vow had been confirmed and pronounced by Sir Thorarin, a sign of life was straight seen in the boy. Then was the child baptized 'Laurence.' When he grew a mighty man, he kept that vow: and after he became bishop at Holar, he kept St. Laurence' Day with high festival, doing the prelude in the mass himself, keeping it a day of banquet, and giving much alms on the same.

7

1267

8

In the birth-year of Laurence these things befell abroad. Hákon, archbishop in Nidarôs, and Prince Olaf died. Charles, king in Apulia, went on a crusade to Jerusalem; also Lewis his brother, king of the Franks. Then appeared Mary Magdalen and was set in the shrine of St. Maximin. In the second year of Laurence' life John was consecrated archbishop at Nidarôs. Conrad was beaten by King Charles out by Rimini, and fled to Benevento, and was there beheaded.

9

1269

10

Then died Earl Gizurd, and Sigvard bishop in Skálholt, and Gauti bishop of the Faroe Isles. In the third year of Laurence' life the Icelanders consented to pay tribute to King Magnûs. Arni was consecrated bishop to Skélholt, and Erlend to the Faroes. In the fourth year of Laurence' life the Icelanders received laws of King Magnûs. King Lewis put a tribute on King Charles. The following kings died of poison which was cast into wells — the Sultan of Tunis, Theobald of Navarre. James went to Jerusalem. Queen Margaret, and Peter, bishop of Bergen, died.

11

1271

12

In the fifth year of Laurence' life, Philip was crowned king of the Franks; and Norwegian laws came into Iceland. In the sixth* year of Laurence' life there was no Pope for four years running. Clement was the next Pope after Urban. In the seventh year of Laurence' life Gregory, sixth of his name, was made Pope. King Magnûs and Valdimar, king of the Swedes, had a conference. Bishop Jorund went to Norway, and Bishop Arni, Rafn, and Thorvard came to Iceland. There were now disputes in the contest over the glebes. Henry, king of the English, died. In the eighth year of Laurence' life Pope Gregory had a council at Lyons and reformed the faith of the Greeks. Then died James, archbishop of Lund in Denmark. Edward, king of the English, was crowned. Archbishop John visited the country; and a piece came of the Crown of Thorns of our Lord Jesus Christ, which was sent to King Magnûs from Philip, king of France. In the ninth year of Laurence' life, Eirek, son of Duke Birgi, came from Denmark with a troop and strove with Valdimar his brother, aided by Duke Magnûs their brother, and King Valdimar fled into Norway. Then came such mighty hail from heaven on St. Laurence' Eve, in certain spots in the lordship of the Thronds, that the largest hailstones weighed fifteen ounces.

13

1276

14

In the tenth year of Laurence' life died Pope Gregory, and Pope Innocent, and Pope Adrian, who was not a priest, but the chief of the cardinals, and called Octobonus. John the Twenty-first was Pope. In Tûnsberg King Magnûs gave the title of Earl to Magnûs, son of Magnûs, Earl of the Orkneys.

15

Now while we have been speaking of those matters to begin with, Laurence stayed in turn with the priest Thorarin his kinsman at Vellir, or else with his father and mother, where they were keeping house; and now he was taught. It was soon manifest that he was eager to learn good.

16

4. Once at Vellir this befell. The schoolboys were brawling in the church there at Vellir; and it so happened that something Laurence threw hit the image of Our Lady and broke off a leaf of the sceptre she was holding. And when Sir Thorarin came to church at even, the lads told him of Laurence' misdoing; and he was very wroth thereat, and vowed him a sound hiding on the morrow. When Laurence knew that this must be fulfilled even as it was promised him, he betook him for help where there was good store of it; he flung down weeping on the floor before Our Lady's image, prayed for aid from her and forgiveness; and especially that the heart of his kinsman might be softened towards him. Next morning Priest Thorarin called his kinsman Laurence, and asked him whether he had put up any prayer to escape his thrashing. He said he had made one to Mary Queen.

17

'I doubt as much,' said Sir Thorarin, 'for in the night it was revealed to me that it was Our Lady's will that I should not beat thee for this, but should have thy breakage mended.' This was a sign that his appeals and prayers, which were acceptable in his childish years to God and his sweet Mother, would be much more so afterwards.

18

When Sir Thorarin was dead and gone, Kålf took it so to heart that he could scarce bear up, and soon he departed. Money after that was scant and hard to find; and yet Thorgrima and her husband had lived long on the lands of the church at Holar. Lord Bishop Jorund asked the lad Laurence to his house at Holar, and put him to book-learning, saying he thought that this lad Laurence would gain much understanding in the lore and learning of books. Year after year went by, so that Laurence waxed in book lore and knowledge, and was best of all the scholars of his years. Sir Ôblaud Hallvardsson was schoolmaster there, and he took such a liking to this youth Laurence that he always made him stay in the school and question the other scholars, when he was himself feasting and drinking with Bishop Jorund. (The aforesaid Sir Ôblaud was near of kin to the Lord Bishop, and had before then been abroad and much loved by the archbishop in Nidaros; and Lord Bishop Jorund bore much love to Sir Ôblaud his kinsman.) Often, when the other scholars were at play or other lightmindedness, there stayed Laurence bettering his mind, studying books, or teaching others. There was much play of malice among the other scholars at this: there, they said, went a bishop-elect; and much fleering and flouting they had at him; but he only went on the further at bettering his mind. His orders proceeded regularly and duly, and the more swiftly, because he was a better scholar than others. And as soon as he was hallowed under Holy Orders, he was appointed at home at Holar and there was deacon. As soon as Laurence was twenty-two he was ordained priest by Lord Bishop Jorund, and then he kept school. He got so toward in scholarly composing of Latin prose and verse that he could make verse as fast as a man could talk Latin.

19

1277

20

5. Turn we back again to the events that befell here in the country and elsewhere. In the eleventh year of Laurence died Pope John. King Magnûs gave the title of Baron to his liegemen. Hrafn was knighted.

King Magnûs and Archbishop John made a lasting settlement between Church and Crown, and confirmed it with their hand and seal. In the twelfth year of Laurence, King Magnûs demanded a levy to go to the Elfi. Bishops Ami and Jorund were reconciled. The bones of Odd, son of Thôrarin, were carried to the church in Skâlholt. In the next year after, Bishops Ami and Jorund went abroad. Hrafn came home, and Lodin of Bakki with lawman's powers. Abbot Vermund of Thingeyri died. In the next year, Pope Nicholas died, and also King Magnûs Hâkonarson. King Eirek was crowned. Bishops Jorund and Ami, Lodin the 'Rag,' and John the lawman with a new code, came home. Bjami was consecrated abbot to Thingeyri. Next year Martin was consecrated Pope. Lodinn the 'Rag's' journey to Norway took place. Eirek, king of Norway, took Queen Margaret, daughter of Alexander, king of Scotland, to wife. Moreover in the next year the houses in Nidarôs were burnt. Lord Archbishop John died out east in Skarir, having been exiled from Norway in the same year.

21

1283

22

In the next year after Lord Hrafn and Lord Lawman Erlend came to Iceland and raised claim to the demesnes in Iceland. Then a great plague overran Iceland. Also next year quarrelling arose between Hrafn on one side, and Bishop Arni and those who were appointed to livings, on the other. Stock perished, and many men died of famine in Iceland, and there was desolation of many homesteads. Also next year, the title of Earl was given to Lord Alf and to Audun 'Oats'.

23

Also next year King Eirek sent Sir Gudmund Hallsson to Iceland to demand men for a levy.

24

This same Gudmund came to Iceland with the vestments which King Eirek had given to St. John, bishop of Holar. It came to pass that King Eirek was on his way to a council of kings and could not get a wind.

Prayers were made to many saints, but it was granted none the more. Then came Sir Gudmund to the king, saying: —

25

‘Pray, Sire, to John, bishop of Holar; he is very swift to hearken to prayers; and offer him your best robes of rich stuff.’

26

‘Thus shall it be done, Sir Priest,’ said the king, ‘and let him show he is no sluggard, as Icelanders commonly are.’

27

Then the calm ended. Straightway Sir Gudmund bade them hoist sail, and forthwith a fair and good wind came blowing; and the king in four days reached the harbour he had chosen, and he honoured St. John, bishop of Holar, ever after. And dalmatics were made of the clothes at Holar. Also in the next year came Jorund, archbishop-elect to Nidaros. Hallkell ‘Crow-dance’ was put to death. Alf was exiled and outlawed; and also Queen Ingibjorg died.

28

1288

29

6. Next year Bishop Jorund and Lord Thorvard came to Iceland. Laurence, as we said before, was now ordained priest; and he was now twenty-two. Here he was priest for three years and also schoolmaster. When Laurence was twenty-five, Bishop Jorund gave him a benefice up north at Hals in Fnjdskdale. He was a year there, and then gave up the living because he had ill luck with his stock in his housekeeping; he was then shifted back to Holar. In the second year of Sir Laurence’ priesthood, it came to pass that King Eirek sent Hrolf to Iceland on a search for the New World. Bishop Jorund of Holar went over the diocese of Bishop Ami to reclaim glebes for the Church, by the counsel of Archbishop Jorund.

30

1290

31

In the year following Bishop Jorund went abroad and stayed two years in Norway; during this time Sir Halldor Grimsson was official over Holar See, and Sir Haflidi Steinsson was steward at Holar. Sir Haflidi was the best of overseers for all secular counsel; he had before this been to Norway, and was chaplain for some years of King Eirek and the queen. Laurence and Sir Haflidi became most friendly and companionable together; often afterwards Laurence testified that he had been a most trusty friend to him. In the third year of Laurence' priesthood, Hrolf wanted men in Iceland for a voyage to the New World.

32

1292

33

Then arose dispute between Archbishop Jorund and the canons in Nidaros. In the following year was the voyage home of Lord Bishop Jorund, and Bishop Arni, of Lord Thord of Christopher, and many others with writs from the king. Then began a fresh contest over the glebes. Sigurd was told to quit Hlid, at Modruvellir, in the Hôrg Valley, and he thought himself entitled, by inheritance, to keep his land. This displeased Bishop Jorund, who gave him many admonitions; and yet he budged from his estate not a whit the more. And it came to this, that he was ready to excommunicate him. Then he bade Sir Laurence go north to Modruvellir with a letter of excommunication which he was to announce before Sigurd, if he refused to quit. Laurence took this journey so sadly that he went with one man north over the Pass of Hédinn, got to Modruvellir, and talked to yeoman Sigurd declaring to him that if he would not obey and come to terms, heavy affliction would befall him. Sigurd took Laurence' words heavily, saying that it was nought to him what he said. Then, next day, when high festival came on, Sir Laurence read the Bishop's writ at mass after Gospel, so loud and clear that Sigurd heard, and all who were in the church. And this was the tenor of the writ: Bishop Jorund laid the ban on Sigurd and barred him from communication with Christian men. From

Sigurd and his men Laurence got many revilings and threatenings, and such array was made against him that it was hardly safe for him to leave the church.

34

Then straightway yeoman Sigurd departed and went west to Holar with much company. At first Sigurd said bitterly that it misbeseeemed the bishop to bear so hard on the king's lieges. And he asked, Did the bishop own that he had bidden Laurence proceed thus? But the bishop said that Laurence had not acted in the way he had bidden him. The end was that Sigurd and the bishop made a bargain: the bishop paying a sum to Sigurd, while church and bishop were to have freehold of the living for ever. Then Sir Laurence came back, Sigurd having ridden off from Holar. And from this journey Laurence earned but labour and trouble; from Sigurd despitfulness and hate, and small cheer from the bishop. This was the root of the estrangement between Bishop Jorund and Laurence; for Laurence thought that he had received a great rebuff for the mission which he deemed he had done faithfully. And he desired much to leave Iceland, because he thought he would get little cordiality from Bishop Jorund: also many of the bishop's kin were very short with him.

35

7. Next summer, after 'Flitting-days,' Lord Peter came to Iceland from Eidi-at-Knerri.

36

1293

37

All the northern quarter was appointed to him by the king for his province. Lord Bishop Jorund invited him to Holar, and there he stayed the winter. Sir Laurence and Lord Peter came to feel fast friends. Laurence took counsel with himself and travelled with him in the summer, and talked and questioned with him of many matters entertainingly. Once Laurence asked Lord Peter how men looked or

bore themselves when the sea was bad. 'Variously,' said Peter, 'I tell thee no more about it this time.'

38

1294

39

In the summer after, Sir Laurence rode south into Skálholt. It is notable that Lord Bishop Arni Thorláksson, who was in authority there, welcomed Laurence so signally that he made him sit next to him. Many marvelled that he gave to a poor cleric a seat higher than distinguished people.

40

But the bishop said that some day it would come to his not having the lowest seat; also he said it was not wrong to set high those who had the better wits. Afterwards the lord bishop called Laurence into his study and set out before him a lectern and upon it a book of the Canon Law, telling him to amuse himself with it. Then said Laurence to the bishop:

—

41

'My good Lord, God requite you for your condescension which you show to me, so poor, so nameless.'

42

The bishop answered: 'If thou hast not yet fully comprehended the Canon Law, that must be thy business henceforth. Also, thou shalt come to endure many tribulations ere thy days be done.' Laurence used to say that he had seen the face of a saint on two men only; on Bishop Arni Thorláksson, and on Bjarni abbot of Thingeyri. Bishop Arni and Laurence parted cordially.

43

1294

44

That same summer Laurence embarked for Norway at Gaseyri with the aforesaid Lord Peter, leave being first obtained from Bishop Jorund.

When they got on the sea, Laurence was in great distress from sea-sickness. Then came Lord Peter to him and said, fleeing:—’ Priest, in the winter at Holar, thou askedst me what figure people cut when the sea was bad; and now I will answer all thy questions; even as pale and peaked as thou art, Sir Laurence.’

45

Laurence had now double pangs — from Lord Peter’s flouting and also from the sea-sickness. They got a fair wind and reached Norway safe and sound. It befell in that year that there was a great earthquake in Iceland in the *March 12*, south, before St. Gregory’s Day, so that in some places houses fell down. There was strife in Rome, and people slain in St. Peter’s.

46

8. Now we must go on to tell how Lord Peter and Sir Laurence came to Norway. King Eirek was then sojourning in Bergen. The king received Lord Peter most blithely, for he was a dear friend of the king’s. Lord Peter broached his suit towards a certain woman of the king’s kindred, who lived east in Vik; he entreated that the king would write to her. The king bade Lord Peter have a letter written in Latin and told him he would give him his seal on it. Then Lord Peter called Laurence to him and bade him compose this letter in the best Latin he knew. Sir Laurence tried to shirk it, and said he was not skilled enough for this. ‘But,’ he said, ‘though I have little skill to do this, yet am I bound to do what you will.’ Next day he showed Lord Peter the letter, written in Latin. Then Lord Peter went to the king with the letter and showed it him. The king praised the handwriting and style of the letter much, and then asked who had done it. Peter answered him that a certain Icelandic priest had done it, whom he had brought from Iceland. The king bade him tell that priest to be at his banquet for that day. Even so Laurence did, and it was arranged he should sit above the other guests, and for that day the king ate and drank to him. The next day a page of the king came to Sir Laurence and told him that the king summoned him. He went to the king in his public hall and gave him good-day. The

king received him cheerily, and asked whether he was the priest who had written Lord Peter's Latin letter; and he said that it was so. The king offered him to wait upon his service. Sir Laurence thanked the king for his offer, and said that he had leave of absence for his pilgrimage to St. Ôlaf in Nidaros.

47

'Come to us,' said the king, 'when thou returnest, and be at our banquet for Yule and all high-days, and whensoever thou wilt.' Also throughout the winter he was in the hall with the king, but sometimes at Lord Peter's charges. There were there with King Eirek many mighty men from divers countries and skilled in many matters. Among them was a man named Thrând 'Cracker,' who knew of many clever tricks, but more by his mother-wit than by any manner of sorcery; he was Flemish by race. Sir Laurence struck up a friendship with this man, and talked about many things to him, for while he was young he went much after laying up of knowledge, and yet he never dealt in sorcery or heathen witchcraft. In Yule Thrând 'Cracker' let off the war-crack; it comes so loud that very few men could bear to hear it, women with child fall in labour when they hear it, and men fall down out of their seats on the floor, or are troubled otherwise. Thrând told Laurence that he should put his fingers in his ears when the crack came. Many men could not stand it in the hall when he made the crack. Thrand explained to Laurence what it was needful to have to make the crack, namely four things: fire, brimstone, parchment, and tow. Now men often use this war-crack in battle, to the end that they who are not used to it may fly all ways.

48

9. Next spring Laurence went north to Thronðhjem where Archbishop Jorund abode: between him and the Chapter there was much dissension.

49

1295

50

Archbishop Jorund was a great lord, a good scholar, a firm friend, very bountiful to his people, and the comeliest of men to look upon. A little before, a great scholar, John the Fleming, had come there. He had abode long in Paris and Orleans, studying, and was so great a lawyer that there in Norway there was none like him, and in this way the archbishop found him a pillar of strength when he was there; for all the foremost of the Chapter were his adversaries. They were constantly appealing to the Pope, and got a number of rescripts from the Curia to burden the archbishop. So the archbishop was very glad to find a scholar wherever he could. John the Fleming was a good mediator for the archbishop in his disputes with the Chapter, because he could not speak any Norse, and the people could not understand his speech; for he spoke all in Latin, French, or Flemish. At this time Sir Laurence came to Throndhjem begging leave to speak with Archbishop Jorund, and when this was got, he showed him the permit from Bishop Jorund at Holar, declaring that he gave Sir Laurence leave to stay with the archbishop as long as he liked to have him by him.

51

Hereat the archbishop was very glad and spoke thus: 'Many thanks give we to Bishop Jorund because he sent thee to us; thou shalt be welcome among us in the Lord; but come to us on the morrow and show us thy handwriting, and whether thou canst compose aught in Latin.'

52

Next day came Sir Laurence to the archbishop, holding a scroll. The archbishop looked at it, and praised the writing and said, 'Read before us that which thou hast written.'

53

He read from it the verses which he had made upon Lady Hallbera, abbess at Stad.

54

'Is she a good woman,' said the archbishop, 'since thou hast praised her so much?'

55

‘People in Iceland,’ said Laurence, ‘count that for certain.’

56

‘Cease verse-making henceforward,’ said the archbishop, ‘and study rather in the Canon Law. Knowest thou not that *Versificatura nihil est nisi falsa figura?*’

57

‘You must also know,’ said Laurence, ‘that *Versificatura nihil est nisi maxima curai* Then the archbishop had John the Fleming summoned, and said to him, ‘We give this man Sir Laurence into your charge, and bid you take all pains in teaching him the Canon Law. We will give you good guerdon for that. — But why do you wear red clothes,’ he said to Sir Laurence, ‘which it is forbidden to clergy to wear?’

58

He said, ‘Because I have no others.’

59

Then he whispered to one of his pages, who went away and came in a little after with fine brown clothes, which the archbishop had worn himself. Then he said to Laurence, ‘Wear these clothes on high days; but get from the Steward at our manor money to buy you black clothing to wear every day: but give these red clothes to your page. Sit at table on the Steward’s bench by John the Fleming.’

60

10. Now to tell how Sir Laurence, after coming to Archbishop Jorund, went daily to study to learn Canon Law, and how sometimes the archbishop sent him to declare his bidding in the quarrels of the Chapter, which were then going forward. Quickly Laurence became best beloved by the archbishop, because he seemed to him shrewd and well-counselled, firm, and quick in argument.

61

1296

62

Next winter, in Lent, on *Laetare Jerusalem* Sunday, the archbishop had Laurence summoned into his chapel at mass.

63

‘Forasmuch as,’ he said, ‘this Sunday is notable, we will give you Ôlafs church here in the town, for it is now free.’

64

Laurence thanked him for all the good treatment he had vouchsafed him. This is a token what love the archbishop had towards him, that he took thought of himself and unasked to give him a church which many men wanted.

65

1294

66

In this year, spoken of already, Adrian the Hermit was consecrated Pope on the day of the Holy Ghost, and called Celestinus. There were standing by him ten lepers, and by God’s mercy they were all cleansed utterly. Celestinus did not last quite till St. John’s Eve, and gave up the Popedom, going back to his hermitage. Then one of the Cardinals Benedict was chosen and consecrated, and called Boniface.

67

1295

68

Eirek, king of the Danes, and Duke Christopher took the Archbishop of Lund and put him in a dungeon. Denmark was under interdict. Bishop Jorund of Holar founded a cloister of canons at Môdruvellir, in the Vale of Hôrg. Then died Ljotr, abbot at Múnka-Thverâ. Then was the great drift of whales in the North of Iceland. At this time Bishop Jorund also founded a nunnery at Stad in Reynisnes. Next year Bishop Jorund made Teit prior at Môdruvellir.

69

1320

70

A great plague of boils ran over Iceland; and twelve yeomen in Skalholt See confirmed Church-property by oath.

71

11. Now we must go on to tell how Laurence was with Archbishop Jorund in Nidaros and studied continually in the Canon Law which Master John the Fleming taught 1296-8 him. Also they were great friends one to another. It seemed great sport to Laurence when John made struggles to talk Norse, but got a very little way with it.

72

Once John the Fleming said to Laurence; 'I would thou wouldst intercede with my Lord that he should present me to the living of the church of Mary here in the town, for it is now empty.'

73

Laurence answered, 'How should that be, when you do not know how to speak any Norse?'

74

'I know,' said John, 'as much as I want, and as lies upon my mind to speak.'

75

'Now,' said Laurence, 'let us then suppose that the beginning of the long fast is come. 'It is then your business to declare before your parish folk how they are to keep the long fast.'

76

'In this wise,' said John the Fleming. 'Now *Lent* is come: every Christian man come to church: get him shriven: put away his wife: make no brawling. *Nonne sufficit domine?*'

77

Then Laurence laughed and said, 'The people understands not what *Lent* is.'

78

He told the archbishop, and they had great sport thereat. But they granted unto John some portion of his request, because he was very

quick of temper if things were not done as he liked.

79

12. Once a great company of passengers for Iceland came to Throndhjem, and there were many Icelanders among them. Sir Laurence wished to do some service to each and all of them. Among the rest came the man called Klaeng the 'Caster,' a kinsman of Laurence and intimate with him.

80

And when John the Fleming saw that, he wanted to pay some attention to him, and once spoke to Laurence in Latin, and said, 'Teach me how to greet this companion of yours in Norse.' Laurence thought he would have a great jest with John and said, 'Thus greet him: *Small welcome, fellow!*'

81

'I understand,' said John: 'this must be a fair greeting, because *fdgnudr* means *gaudium*, and *laus* 'praise.' Afterwards he went up to Klaeng the Caster, clapped him on the shoulders and said, 'Small welcome, fellow!'

82

The other sharpened his looks at him, and he thought the greeting could not be so fair as he had supposed.

83

Then said John the Fleming to Laurence, 'Now I understand that thou hast mocked me, for this man was wroth with me.'

84

John the Fleming had a mistress so hideous and loathsome that there could scarcely be found a more monstrous aspect than she wore. Sir Laurence once asked Master John wherefore he would keep so very hideous a woman in his company. John answered, 'I am a hot-tempered man, and I should not take it well if any one were to fool my serving-woman away from me, and therefore I took this one because I know that no man wants her.'

85

13. It is said that now the discussion of Archbishop Jorund and the Chapter waxed so that it broke into open hatred. His chief adversaries were Sighvat the Landsman, and Sir Eilif, afterwards archbishop in Nidaros, and Sir Audun the Red, afterwards bishop at Holar in Iceland. They appealed to Pope Boniface: the end was that Archbishop Jorund was summoned to the Pope, so he went out of the country to Paris; where he took ill, and went no further. Thence he sent a message to the Pope and then got back his credit. He was away there one year and then came back to Nidaros. During that time Laurence was in Nidaros and had St. Ôlafs Church, as we told before. He was glad when the archbishop came back home, for he then appointed Sir Laurence in charge over the offering which was made to Olaf, saint and king, and also to be penitentiary. Then the archbishop paid even more regard to him than before, because he seemed to him to have gone on deftly about his business and his church in his own absence.

86

In that year Bishop Àrni Thorláksson departed; and he was buried at Munklif in Bergen.

87

1299

88

In the next year died King Eirek Magnusson on the 10th of July. The title of king was given to Hâkon his brother, who was crowned with the hallowing of a king in Throndhjem by Archbishop Jorund. Thither now came all the first men in Norway and from other lands far and wide. There could be seen the greatest throng ever known in the Northern lands. No man might go out from Eyri and on to Christ Church except with eider-down robes, costly stuff, and canopy. King Hâkon gave a magnificent feast and also many privileges and amended laws to the Holy Church. King Hâkon reconciled the Archbishop and the Chapter. But it lasted only a while, for the moment that King Hâkon was out of the town, the same quarrelling and wrangling arose between them as of old. So things stayed for a year. Then the

archbishop proceeded against them with admonitions, and they would not obey. In league with them now went all the people of the town, all the school, and the abbot from Holm. The end was that no lettered man dared or would execute any bidding of the archbishop's which the Chapter were against.

89

14. One day the archbishop summoned Laurence and said, 'Here is a writ which John the Fleming has made by our bidding. This writ thou art to read out against the Chapter in Christ Church to-morrow morning, because that is a day of most high festival.'

90

Laurence answers, '*Mighty is the master's word*; I must do and forward whatever is your will while I am in your service. But I know that, little as the Chapter have loved me hitherto, now it will be yet worse.'

91

Accordingly on the morrow at high mass, when the Chapter were in the chancel, and when it was least expected, Sir Laurence rose up in the choir, according to the bidding of the archbishop, and read the writ: — *Rumor pestiferus!*... This was the drift of the writ, that for many and mighty reasons which he named, he laid a ban on the Canons Eilif, Audun the Red, Sighvat the Landsman, saying also that if they did not quit, the service of mass was to cease. Laurence read so loudly and well that they heard clearly.

92

Then answered Sighvat the Landsman, saying, 'No need, Icelfander, to bellow so loud, we hear what thou sayest.' They all went home each to his lodging. From that day forth Sir Laurence could never go out without danger from the Chapter.

93

This year it befell in Iceland that fire came up from Mount Hekla so violently that the mountain was cloven, which will be there to see while Iceland is dwelt 1300 in. In this fire great stones whirled wildly about like coal in hardness, so that, when they drove together, the

cracks were so great that it was heard over the country northwards and far and wide elsewhere. Thence came so much lava, smiting on a farm in Naefraholt, that the thatch was burnt off the buildings. A wind came from the south-west which carried sand over the country between Vatn Pass and the Heath of Oxar Firth so thickly with so mighty a darkness, that no man, in doors or out, knew whether it was night or day, until the sand fell to earth in a shower, and all the earth was hid for the sand. On the next day the sand drifted, so that here and there men could scarce grope their way. All these two days no man durst row on the sea, because of the darkness over the north country.

94

Dec 31

95

This befell on the 13 th of July. At the same time a fire burst up in Sicily and two dioceses were burnt. Likewise on the sixth night of Yule, such a great earthquake came over the south country that the land shook far and wide. A homestead fell in East Skard; in the church there was a great brazen caldron fixed against the ledge of the beam of the church: it smote with the shock so hard against the church roof that the caldron broke. Two chests stood in the porch in Naefraholt, and they were clashed by the earthquake together so mightily that both were brayed into fine powder. And all the chronicles witness that thirteen hundred years had gone by from the coming upon earth of our Lord Jesus Christ until that day.

96

15. Now to take up the story. Many ambushes were laid for Sir Laurence. Once it came to pass that the clerks leapt upon him and desired to take him; and when he saw it, he took to his heels and sped up to Christ Church and got hold of the ring of the church door. Then they sped after him; then all at once they tore off his gown, and meant to gripe him away from the church; and then the archbishop's lads came to help him, for he called out for their aid. Also it befell once that a great lady in the place, in the parish of St. Ôlaf s Church, died;

requiems were sung according to wont, and there was torch and taper. Sir Laurence with his fellows sang the requiems. Then came many scholars all at once and laid hands on the waxen torches and tapers: they were the stronger, and he had no power of defending himself. On the morrow the archbishop sent his lads, so that he got the masses sung and the body lowered. So many offences and mockeries and rebuffs did Sir Laurence endure, ever after he read the aforesaid writ before the Chapter, at the hands of the scholars and of all their train, that the tale were long to tell.

97

Now to tell how Archbishop Jorund was high in the graces of Lord Hâkon the king; to whom wrote the archbishop, showing what affliction and disquiet the Chapter brought upon him, and begging that he would come himself and chastise them with royal authority. And Lord Hâkon the king did so; he came to Throndhjem with a crowd both of the clergy and laity, and appointed a moot, summoning thither the archbishop and all the canons, his adversaries, and all the great men of the town. The moot was held in the summer-palace. There was with King Hâkon a great doctor called Aki who had been studying abroad, a leading and eloquent scholar, and he was retained to speak on the king's behalf. A reading-desk was set before him: he stood out before the king's dais. The order was this; the king and the archbishop sat together, and out in line from the king the knights and chief men of the kingdom, and out in line from the archbishop the suffragans and abbots, and beyond them the Chapter. On the floor sat priests and common folk. And there among the other companions of the archbishop was Sir Laurence. Lord Aki, calling with a loud voice, gave the signal for the people to hearken. First he set to making an eloquent speech in Latin, telling how it befitted princes both in temporal authority and spiritual to have pre-eminence: this speech of his lasted long. Then he translated his speech and delivered it in clear and eloquent Norse; keeping to the theme how it was meet for meaner men to do homage to their betters, not merely towards the good and

righteous, but equally towards such as are tainted in their walk; as Paul the apostle saith, declaring how heavy an iniquity it is for a man to conspire against his superiors, and making it as grievous as idolatry. Then he went on to speak more boldly, saying plainly into what abomination the Chapter had fallen in working adversely to their lord archbishop: saying plainly also, that they might suffer in their skins, and that the secular arm could rightfully fall on them with the king's sword and authority. And so sharp and loudly this man spoke that many of the Chapter and their retainers shivered in their shirts.

98

16. After Lord Aki's speech, King Hâkon stood up and spoke in Latin and in Norse; and the end of it was that he gave them a hard choice; — either those canons who had been declared under the ban by the archbishop were to be outlawed from Norway and all his dominion, they and all their followers, or else they must fall down on the spot before the archbishop and submit all their case to his power by the counsel of the king and the chief men; and yet if they did not there and then do the king's bidding, they should by no means now quit that chamber unscathed. Now, when the canons saw what a great peril was between them and the door, they straightway stood up and fell down before the archbishop and submitted all their case unto his will. Next day the covenant between the archbishop and the Chapter was declared. Each made a covenant of peace and quietness with the other and the other's men: which covenant was most loyally kept for two years, and Sir Laurence was now in peace and quietness and well entertained by Archbishop Jorund; he was also penitentiary, and appointed to the charge of the offering to St. Ôlaf.

99

We would not pass by declaring and expounding what befell abroad during these years. It is said that a rich prince fought in Rome herself, but afterwards made peace with Pope Boniface, taking his niece to wife. And the Lord Pope went so far for the peace of holy Church that he

himself solemnised their marriage, and gave dispensation to eat meat on Palm Sunday, but he forbade any man doing it at his pleasure.

100

1301

101

That year died Chancellor Bârd: Lord Alf of Krôk came out, and two quarters of Iceland were appointed unto him, the North and East. Then came out to Iceland Lodin, the lawman, with a writ from the king. In the next year following Audun' Oats' was hanged, and Margaret, who boasted she was King Eirek's daughter, and her husband were burned. A comet was seen about Michaelmas time, by traders on the sea, and it seemed to them greater and dimmer than other stars, and had a tail like a plummet, and every evening that they saw it, it went tail foremost from the north-east northwards. Also in the South country a comet was seen for half a month on winter nights: also in Bergen towards Lent, and in Rome before Easter. Lord Bishop Jorund, at Hôlar, instituted chanting at the new church which he had had built at Môdruvellir in the Hôrg Valley, Krôk Alf came to Norway and told King Hâkon of many changes in Iceland.

102

1304

103

In that following year above spoken of Pope Boniface died; Benedict was consecrated Pope, and Arni Helgason also was consecrated bishop to Skâlholt. Thurid, daughter of Arni of Burgundy, bore a boy to Sir Laurence, called Ami; the same woman afterwards bore a boy to Sir Solomon, called Bârd. In the next year died Pope Benedict, and Clement was consecrated in his stead.

104

17. Then came from Nomay to Iceland Alf Krok with many writs from the king and novellae, with these he went over the country and named many good yeoman outlaws. At Hegranness moot and also at Oddeyri moot the people rushed at him. At Hegranness moot he was so scared

that he hardly knew where to turn for refuge: the vagabond beggars, whooping and hollaing, smote their shields against him; he was only saved from slaughter at their hands by Lord Thord from Modruvellir and other lords having him covered by their shields. There was a fellow called Berg the 'Wren,' a yeoman, and a fat-headed fool; he was also the most forward of all the freedmen in harrying Alf at Hegraness moot. And when Lord Jorund was billeted at Hof in Hofdastrond, and was at table in the evening, into the room burst the aforesaid Berg the Wren, and flung himself down before the bishop's feet, saying, 'Utterly in God's hand and yours, lord bishop!'

105

Bishop Jorund asked, 'What is the matter, Berg?'

106

'I have fallen into a lamentable sin,' said Berg; 'to-day, at Hegraness Thing, I slew Krok-Àlf.'

107

Then asked the bishop, 'How didst thou attack Alf?'

108

'My Lord, I thrust Alf through with a spear: now I offer myself to whatsoever penance it is thy will to put upon me.'

109

'Berg, get up,' said the bishop. 'Berg, thou hast seen wrong; for Krok-Àlf thou hast not slain, and he yet lives. Go to the table and eat; I will not shun commerce with thee: thou art no man-slayer.'

110

'Will that be better known to thee than me, bishop? nay, for the trouble has grown yet greater notwithstanding; I slew yet another man.' So said Berg.

111

'Hold thy peace,' said the bishop, 'and lie not like a fool about thyself. For people already know that thou art none too valiant, and art not

tried in fight and fray; nay, we deem thee more of a coward than any man, when manly prowess is wanted.'

112

Now, when the bishop and Berg had thus parleyed, people came into the room who had been at the moot during the day, and told that Alf was alive and journeying to Lord Thord, and meant to go north over the waste. And the moment that Berg saw the people coming into the room, he took to his heels and flew to the church, and into the chancel, and under the hangings, and there he skulked till the bishop came to the church, and by talking got enough pith into Berg to make him go away with the rest. Ever after, Berg seemed a worse fool than before; everything Bishop Jorund had said proved right; for it was truly said about him that he was shrewder about everything and clearer-witted than any one else in Iceland during his days upon earth. Krok-Àlf went north into Dynhagi and stayed there through the winter, over Yule. Then he took a sickness and died of it, and lies at Môdruvellir in the Vale of Horg. It was told to King Hâkon that Icelanders had slain Alf; but there were many to ginsay this on oath.

113

18. Now to take up the story: Sir Laurence was in Throndhjem, in Nidaros, well entertained, as we said before, by Archbishop Jorund; but many felt great envy at the eminence which the archbishop gave him. One day it happened that the archbishop was holding a Chapter with the canons and the other chief clergy that were then with him. They declared, before the archbishop, that it was meet for him to send a visitor out to Iceland; and proclaiming that the fittest man for that was Sir Laurence, because he was a good scholar and an Icelfander born. With this declaration the archbishop agreed, and called Sir Laurence up, declaring that his will was to send him to Iceland for a visitation with authority from the archbishop. He bade him come again next day, which he did. Then the archbishop said the like to Laurence, that his will was to send him to Iceland. And thus Laurence answered the archbishop's words:

114

‘My Lord, you know well that I do all your will gladly; but I know my own infirmity for all such matters, and especially that I have small practice in preaching God’s message before the people; and if you desire that I adventure on this service, send with me some preacher to hold forth before the people. I have even spoken with brother Bjorn of the preacher’s order; he is willing to go with me if you consent; only, it must be so as to share my power fairly with me, and to be in equal authority with me.’

115

Then said Lord Archbishop Jorund, ‘Thou seest this thing not so clearly, Sir Laurence, as were meet for thy own edification; but thou knowest this well, how our Lord saith: *omne regnum in se divisum desolabitur*; yea, it often happens that a kingdom divided against itself shall be swiftly desolate; and there is seldom agreement of one man with another: also discernment will, in this matter, be given unto thee, so that thou will repent greatly of taking a preaching-brother into thy company: for such are ever ill to trust in law-suits and in all other fellowship.’

116

Then the canons held to it — more for malicé towards Laurence than for sound counsel — that he should never be suffered to take brother Bjorn with him. Then the plan was settled, that brother Bjorn and Sir Laurence were appointed visitors to Iceland with equal powers; yet the archbishop was much more close and affectionate with Sir Laurence than with brother Bjorn, but both of them took the strongest letters of authority for their mission. The archbishop showed what love he bore to Sir Laurence, inasmuch as he gave him, with his seal patent, three parchments — the nature of such letters is, that there must be a seal on them, but nought written; then he, to whom they are given out, is to write in them what he likes; swearing first an oath not to write on them aught to the hurt of him who issues them, or to his Church. And this oath Sir Laurence swore, and it was sealed duly, two

trusty men of the archbishop's being by. Also the archbishop wrote warm letters out to Bishops Jorund and Ami, saying that they should show goodwill to the visitors aforesaid and support, as far as their own authority went. Then their visitors got on board a ship on its way to Iceland, and took leave of the archbishop cordially.

117

19. Now to tell how the visitors put to sea, had a fair voyage, landed at Eyri, in the south country, rode up into Skálholt, and were nobly welcomed by Bishop Árni. He bade them stay as long as they had a mind, and gladly they accepted. And when, in summer, the next day before St. Thorlak's Day came, thus said Laurence to brother Bjorn, 'Now in Skálholt is a great congregation from over all Iceland, and thou, brother Bjorn, must ponder over thy morrow's sermon, and especially upon the glory of Thorlak, bishop and saint, for that is now most meet.'

118

Then brother Bjorn answered, 'Strange folk all ye Icelanders are, calling many men who have grown up here among you *saints*, while in other countries men know nothing of them. Thus it is high presumption in you Icelanders to reckon a man a saint whom the archbishop in Nidaros has no cognisance of; nay, to-night, when the clergy think of going to evensong, I must rise up in the chancel, and forbid the bishop and all the clergy to sing of this Thorlak, until he is legally acknowledged by our lord archbishop and all the bishops in the province of the church of Nidaros. And I desire thou wilt do likewise, having power equal with mine.'

119

'Peace, peace,' said Laurence, 'and let this foolishness go no further, for all men, both here in the land and far and wide beyond it, know that the Bishop St. Thorlak is a saint in truth, and did many mighty miracles, and yet doeth; and he will surely punish thee if thou dost not make thy peace with God and this blessed bishop.'

120

The end of their talk was that each held to his own way of thinking. Brother Bjorn called his cook and bade him cook meat for him in Skálholt, the day before St. Thorlák's Day, which seemed passing strange. At evening the bell rang to keep holiday, and when it was come to the time for evensong, a man came in haste to Laurence, saying that brother Bjorn entreated him to come speedily. He went into the room where brother Bjorn lay, and saw him lying on his bed, groaning with sick sobs.

121

Then said brother Bjorn to Laurence, 'Friend, what shall I do? I am fallen on so heavy an affliction that something goes through my heart, so that I think it most likely, if this go on a while, I shall die speedily.'

122

'Small wonder is it,' said Laurence, 'though this befall thee, for thou spokest very foolishly in the morning, in misdoubting the sainthood of this goodly servant of God, the sainted Bishop Thorlák, who manifests many good miracles, and as men know that he is merciful unto them that call upon him, so is he very vengeful to them that trespass against him. Thus a certain fool in England was disposed to think that he would bring shame and gibing upon the Bishop St. Thorlák. He took a sausage of sheep's fat and carried it before the image of Bishop Thorlák, saying, "Have it, Fat-lander? Thou hast come abroad from Iceland." This gibe was avenged so swiftly that the hand which held up the lard sausage became stiff like wood; and there he had to stand where he was, with his hand on high, until pious men prayed for him, and he repented him of his abomination; then he got free.'

123

'Gladly,' said brother Bjorn, 'will I repent, and will consent to believe every word said henceforth about his glory and sanctity, if he will only mend my malady and take it away: may God grant this at his intercession! Also on the morrow I will preach before the good people of his laudable life and miracles.'

124

And when he had thus confessed, straightway came a riddance of all his sickness, so that he stood up whole and preached finely on the morrow before the people concerning Bishop Thorlák, telling clearly and bravely what had befallen him. From this event the Bishop St. Thorlák got glory, renown, and honour in everything, even as he is worthy.

125

After St. Thorlák's Day, the visitors made their visitation, over the Southern and Western quarters first. Sir Laurence looked hard after the performance of service by priests of Dec. 23 small lore and knowledge; many of whom proved of light learning, and among them a priest called Eilff in Gufa-dale in the Western quarter. At mass and lessons the visitors examined him, and the issue was that he knew hardly a thing in either of these matters.

126

Then said Laurence, 'Let us examine him in the canticle *Audite*,' and they did so; and he had no sure knowledge of how to read *Audite*.

127

Priest Eilff said, 'I can do nothing with it, if ye examine me in the hardest thing ye can find.'

128

'Thou hast seldom read the *feriales liturgiae*?' said Laurence, 'that is easy to see.'

129

The visitors took away from Priest Eilff the mass and all the priest's service, until he should know it, or till he learnt enough to make him fit to officiate. There were also some more priests from whom they took, because of their ignorance, the right of saying mass.

130

1307

131

In the summer they visited the See of Skálholt and went to all the cloisters and larger churches; and in the Skálholt See they were not

withstood, for Lord Bishop Arni was a lowly man of gentle bearing. In that summer Lord Bard came to Iceland with writs and amendments from the king.

132

20. Now to tell how when the visitors had gone over the See of Skálholt, they rode to Hôlar and met Lord Bishop Jorund. He received them both civilly, but brother Bjorn far more cordially: Laurence soon found that Lord Bishop Jorund invited brother Bjorn to stay the winter there; but no invitation came to Laurence. Brother Bjorn accepted the bishop's invitation and stayed the winter at Hôlar. Sir Laurence went north over the fell and parted from Bishop Jorund coldly. The bishop's kin did nothing but scoff and jeer at him, casting in his teeth the old days when Bishop Jorund took him up a beggar, and had him taught; 'and now he claimed to have authority over him, and power, by the archbishop's ordinance, to depose him from his episcopal sway.' Many despiteful fellows carried a pack of lies between them. Laurence went to Eyja Firth, and Lord Thôrd invited him to stay the winter with him; he accepted, and stayed the winter there with one lad. Lord Abbot Thôrir was then at Munka-Thverâ.

133

21. In the spring before it had befallen that Solveig, the daughter of Lopt, wife of Thorvald Geirsson, then dwelling in Long Slope in the Horg Valley, went to Baegis Water to service on the eve of Maundy Thursday, and one woman with her. As they both went on, it happened that they went down into the Horg river and were both drowned. The body of goodwife Solveig was found afterwards, and later Thorvald Geirsson took his wife's body to Munka-Thverâ and gave thereafter much offering with the corpse; but she had a right of burial at Baegis Water, where then dwelt the priest called Hildibrand Grimsson. There had been no love lost between Sir Hildibrand and Thorvald; likewise there was a coolness between Solveig and the wife of Thorvald: the priest was for ever comforting Solveig with holy counsel. It was much treasure which Thorvald gave to Munka-Thvera as an offering for her

soul; but to Baegis Water he merely gave twelve ells for a burial-fee. Then in spring Sir Hildibrand complained to Bishop Jorund, but it came to nothing. Afterwards Sir Hildibrand came to Sir Laurence at Modruvellir in Eyja Firth, and complained to him that he thought he had a claim to the offering and the burial-service; also that her body had a right to burial in the churchyard at Baegis Water; moreover her own will and testament did not declare that she had chosen burial anywhere else save at her own parish church in Baegis Water. Laurence wrote a letter to Thorvald admonishing him to dispose the body to be taken back to Baegis Water, or else come to an agreement with the priest and dispose fittingly with the church by a gift for her soul, while her body, with Sir Hildibrand's leave, should have free burial in Múnka-Thverâ. Thorvald took this letter coldly, professing that he cared nothing for what he said, but meant to have the decision of Bishop Jorund. Afterwards Hildibrand went to Múnka-Thvera and claimed the body, demanding it back for that place of burial which was its due; afterwards he entreated the visitors to hear the case and give him his rights.

134

Then Sir Laurence admonished the abbot and brethren to give up the body freely or else come to a bargain with the priest. The abbot and brethren answered coldly and appealed to Bishop Jorund, saying they heeded his words never a whit. Afterwards at home at Môdruvellir Laurence made a writ, and went to Múnka-Thverâ, and one saint's day went up into the choir, and with letters patent laid his judgment upon them, namely; that the body of Solveig, daughter of Lopt, had right of burial at Baegis Water: and forbidding performance of mass there in the church while her body lay there in the churchyard. Their abbot and brethren asked Laurence to give them a copy of the judgment Laurence bade them take the judgment, and declared he would give them a copy then or never; then straightway they departed with it. Next the abbot wrote west to Bishop Jorund and brother Bjorn, and they gave leave to sing again as before in the church. Lord Bishop

Jôrund and brother Bjorn wrote north by the hand of Sir Snjolf; the main thing in the message was that they wished Laurence' writ of judgment to be delivered over into Snjolf's hand, for censure in case he had decided hastily and not heeded the law. It had also been said in the north that it had been read, and that was not proved. Sir Snjolf came to Miinka-Thverd with the aforesaid ordinance; the message was also sent to Sir Laurence and Sir Thôrd. They came; Snjolf read out the letter of Bjorn the visitor, giving leave to chant in the church, till Bishop Jorund and he should take evidence in court after Easter. Bishop Jorund wrote to the same effect. Snjolf called on Laurence to read out his writ of judgment; then Laurence read the writ, and when the writ was finished, the abbot and many with him in the church snatched at the writ, and tore writ and seal away. Then Laurence and his friend were haled and thrust out of church and churchyard, and there was no more violence done to men's hurt. Laurence had such odds against him, that it was doubtful if he would not have received hurt had not Lord Thord given him help and aid. Thus began the estrangement of Laurence and Bishop Jorund. Then, as often, Snjolf was the chief adversary of Laurence. There was peace now till after Easter.

135

22. After the day of Bishop John of Holar, Lord Jorund and brother Bjorn rode north to Modruvellir in the Hôrg April 23 Valley, and summoned before them Hildibrand, the priest at Baegis Water, and like-wise Thorir, the abbot at Mûnka-Thverâ, and the bishop made covenant of peace between them. Solveig's body was to have free burial at Mûnka-Thverâ. But the priest got off somewhat poorly. For the end of the suit was that Bishop Jorund was complete master over whatever men in the See of Hôlar there were to deal with. For finally all men were willing to sit down and stand up and let all things go according to his will; for he was wise in all the wisdom of this world, and free with his money. To this covenant Laurence was no party; yet he rode to Môdruvellir to meet them; and then came his parting and estrangement from brother Bjorn; it was plain that brother Bjorn

would let everything go according to the will of Bishop Jorund. Laurence made this request of him, that they should heed the archbishop's bidding, visiting from church to church and looking after church causes. Brother Bjorn declared he would not drift about the desert in Hôlar diocese, but would go south to his ship, and go back to Norway.

136

'This is my wish,' said Laurence, 'that we heed as best we can my lord archbishop's business, and visit over all Hôlar diocese, and get afterwards on the ship that is now here at Gâseyri, and go back in it to Norway in the summer.'

137

'Do as seems good to thee,' said brother Bjorn; 'thou keepest me not from my purpose.'

138

Now the plan Bishop Jorund had made with him really was that he should embark from the South, and reach Norway ere Laurence, and defame his doings.

139

'Then wilt thou be willing to consent that I take upon me the business of us both,' said Laurence.

140

'Manage as thou likest,' said brother Bjorn.

141

Brother Bjorn went back home to Holar with Bishop Jorund, and there Laurence parted with him, and thought he himself had fallen into a heavy plight; all his business in the North quarter unperformed! He took counsel thereon with his friends, what was next to be done; for he perceived all the counsel of Bishop Jorund, knowing his wish was to have a swift riddance of the visitors. North of the heath they counselled him to assume all authority and visit on visitor's business, and oppose Bishop Jorund if he would not hearken to the archbishop's bidding. Then he wrote to his dear friend Hafliði Steinsson, asking his

counsel. He wrote back, that he should go back in the same ship as brother Bjorn, and meet the Archbishop and Chapter at the same time as he; but he bade him beware most of all lest he opposed Bishop Jorund in anything, or wrought at all against his will, saying that, good scholar as he was, that was not enough to make him prevail over Bishop Jorund because of the luck and lordship that was his; and that he might do himself great harm by striving with him in any way.

142

And when this advice came back to Laurence, he said, 'I know that Sir Hafliði, my comrade, wishes me well; but for the love and friendship he bears Bishop Jorund, he will not hear of any man speaking or acting against him; but I am bound to do my lord archbishop's bidding.'

143

So he took up the harder way for himself, of staying behind in the Northern quarter. But brother Bjorn went first to Skalholt and then on board. He was then given many fine gifts by Bishop Jorund, who sent a letter abroad by him to the Archbishop and Chapter.

144

In that winter, then past, this had befallen in the south of Iceland; so mighty an earthquake came, that eighteen farms fell down because of it. And in Norway the news was that Lord Archbishop Jorund fell very sick, in this way; that gout first attacked his leg, and then struck up into his body. The Chapter took unto them all rule and authority in temporal even as in spiritual matters, so that there remained by him only two lads and his cook. All were now turned out who had heretofore been his friends or supporters in lawsuits.

145

23. Now to take up the story. Brother Bjorn being gone from Holar diocese, and Laurence left, Laurence was prompted by some to start on his visitor's business, and he did so. No man heeded his word; every claimant appealed to Bishop Jorund, and no entertainment was given him as he journeyed. Then he rode home to Hôlar, and asked the bishop to yield him a night's lodging at his bishop's seat; the bishop

said he was not bound to, because the other, his equal in authority, had left the bishopric. Laurence said, that though he would fain disregard visiting or looking after the archbishop's business before he were worn to death, yet he would liefer proceed with his bounden duty. About this the bishop and Laurence came to no terms. Then on a high-day, which was near at hand, Laurence went up into the choir and spoke of many sins, which went on there at home at the seat, and chiefly of filthy living and incests.

146

This touched the daughters of Bodvar, kinswomen of the bishop, most home, 'since,' he said, 'no man heard of their paying public penance, fasting, or standing outside the church door; and it was just the same far and wide over in Holar diocese; and there was much reckless conduct.' Straightway a clamour arose. In the hearing of all he ended his discourse by saying that men should quit their evil ways and turn and mend. To this admonishings and helpful teaching, the bishop's kinswomen heeded not a whit; nay, when he came out of church, after mass, he got revilings and many words of contumely from the bishop's kindred. There were so many differences now between Bishop Jorund and Laurence, that at last it broke into open feud. Laurence saw that, now that the bishop was so adverse to him, he could carry out no chastisement upon the people, so he took passage in the Gâseyri ship. Bishop Jorund also sent abroad a certain priest of his own called Gudmund Halldôrsson, with much treasure and gifts to the Archbishop and Chapter, and letters against Laurence.

147

Bishop Jorund was becoming very worn with years; he had long kept at home and was loath to visit or vex himself. Laurence had made note of many suits, which had gone on to his knowledge in a very slovenly fashion, specially suits about marriage. At the last, when the traders were ready to sail, Laurence went to Hôlar, and then had an interview with the bishop. Then Laurence read out all the heads he had drawn up about the careless and lawless ways of the bishop.

148

‘Nor will I hide from you, my lord bishop, that all these things I will read out before the archbishop.’

149

Then Bishop Jorund spoke more softly, and thus said: ‘I ask you this, Sir Laurence, that we let our suit drop, and write in harmony with one another; we will write about thee favourably to the archbishop; tear this letter in pieces which thou now hast read out touching it, and swear an oath of faith and fealty to us.’

150

Laurence said, ‘I know that so great is your kingdom, power, and lordship, that you can overcome and put me down; but not so much as to make me break that oath which I swore before my Lord archbishop, that I would tell him truly of the doings of the bishops and suits.’

151

And scarce had he got the words out, when Bishop Jorund leapt up straightway, and Laurence could get no speech with him, and so they parted. Laurence went north to Gåseyri, and so on board.

152

Aug 27, 1308

153

The traders put to sea nigh on St. Bartholomew’s Day. They had a poor wind and were long at sea. At first they went north, towards Naumadale, and then they had a good south wind, and got into Throndhjem in autumn nigh on Michaelmas Day. Now of Bjorn it is to be told, that he had got to Throndhjem on the latter St. Mary’s Day, and had come with the letters and ordinance of Bishop Jorund, Sep. 8 bringing lying tales of Laurence, and stating that he had read out in Iceland many writs of the archbishop, which he said he knew not how Laurence had come at. The Chapter gave ear eagerly to this deliverance of Bjorn; and the plan was straightway laid, that as soon as Laurence arrived from Iceland, all his goods, letters, and documents should be seized, and he thrust into a dungeon. Bjorn slandered him as best he could; but most

credit was given to what Bishop Jorund had written out to the Archbishop and Chapter.

154

24. Now to tell how Laurence had himself taken from the merchant-ship into the town, knowing nothing of what was afoot. They had landed at Holm with no thought of alarm. The Chapter had news of this at once, and sent their men with a few clerics down to the pier; and as soon as Laurence thought of disembarking, and stepped on the pier, the clerics gripped him, saying, 'Thou, Laurence, art to come with us; a lodging is made ready for thee, whereto we must escort thee.'

155

Then straightway a crowd of men-at-arms rushed on him, and at first led him amidst them; and when he saw he was taken, he tried to break away; then they dragged and carried him in turn, and cruelly enough, till they came to a dungeon. It was most foul and called Gulskitni. Down into this he was kicked and plunged; it was cold and foul both, and so dark he could hardly discern his own hands. Then an iron door was locked which was over the dungeon. When Laurence came down on the stone wall, he fell in a swoon; and when he came-to, he crossed himself and bade God help him. Then he raised himself up and found that the place could not hold over three men together. Nor was any living thing there. All this that has just been told was done so swiftly that this man Laurence never got word or oath in his own behalf to absolve him or help his case; and as soon as it was done, the people went to the canons and told them what was done. Then they sent some people out to the merchant-ship to seize the goods Laurence had had in the ship; but the merchants were so faithful that they would not say a word to them, but straight snatched up their arms and made as if they would fight to prevent them ransacking there. Then they took his lad whom he had had with him, and tried to force him to speak; but this he by no means would. Still, they were told by a Thronð trading lad where his boxes were. Straightway there were seized and carried off to the bishop's house all the goods he had, great and little, into the

hands of the canons and of Nidaros Church: the boxes were broken open; and all his writs and documents were confiscated from him and read before the Chapter. They said that they did not know how some of the writs which he had, had come into his hands, for the archbishop had never issued them to him. Yet this was not in the least tested. On the day after Laurence was flung into the dungeon, the canons held a Chapter: no man got in to hear them, and people did not know what they were dealing with. Now to tell of Laurence. He was two nights in the dungeon, and the keeper of the dungeon brought him, night and morning, bread and a little bacon and sour small beer; of this he could take hardly anything. There was a concourse both of those who had been the archbishop's servants and many who had been Laurence's friends in the town when he was duly honoured; and they said plainly to the canons that these were sorry doings of theirs, to seize a man and starve him in a dungeon before inquiry was made of what he had done, or before his suit came on after inquiry. The Chapter said it was easily proved that he had gone to Iceland with a forged writ, had got at the archbishop's seal, and under it had written letters enacting what he himself wanted. Then people said, 'Why was he not to be allowed a meeting with the archbishop?'

156

'Because,' they replied, 'the archbishop was so wroth with him on account of brother Bjorn's report and Bishop Jorund's letter that he would on no account see him.' This was a lie of theirs; for the Chapter seized for themselves all writs and ordinances. They decided all cases, and ruled all things, temporal even as spiritual; but the archbishop lay in his agony with all power confiscated from him. Eilff, chosen archbishop afterwards, was Official; while Sir Audun the Red was the greatest, richest, and most thought of of all the canons, Sighvat the Landsman being now dead. Eilff and Audun bore heaviest upon Laurence because of his having long ago read the writ of ban over them in the choir when no man else dared to. Sir Solomon was newly made canon, having left his studies but a short while ago; he and other

two likewise never went against Laurence; but all the rest were his adversaries.

157

25. Now to go back to tell how, when he had been famished two nights in the dungeon, the canons had him summoned. They all sat on the bench, as the custom was; but he was put down on the floor with fetters on his feet; he spoke very low, for he had been far gone in the dungeon, and before that sea-worn; and so it was to be expected that he would not speak very loud. Yet he greeted them. They answered him never a word. Then they spoke: 'Higher much was thy howling, Sir Laurence, when thou readest the writ of ban over us.'

158

'Be not wroth with me for it,' said he, 'though I did my lord's bidding.'

159

'Now,' they said, 'there shall be manifest and revealed the charges that are brought against thee.'

160

Then there was read the deed they had drawn, saying that two charges were brought against him; one, that he had forged letters of the archbishop's; but this in chief, that he had squandered the goods and offerings of St. Ôlaf when he had to receive the offering and was appointed by the archbishop thereto. This charge had never been brought against him ere he went to Iceland. Then were read the letters written by Jorund, bishop of Holar, to weigh against him. Then Laurence was asked, would he confess to these things without force being used? if so, they would look kindly on his case.

161

Then he said, 'Now, how ye will deal with me lies in your power — whether I am to keep alive or no; but what I have not done, that will I never acknowledge.'

162

Then started up certain of the canons, saying, 'He has not been tried hard enough yet; he will have much more to say if he goes back to

Gulskitni.’

163

Then a choice of two things was offered him: to make there in Norway just what confession the official drew up for him; or else to go back to Iceland under Bishop Jorund’s authority and stay in prison till he sailed.

164

‘I will take,’ said Laurence, ‘what most men least expect. I choose that ye send me back to Iceland under Bishop Jorund’s authority.’

165

The Official proclaimed that the holy church of Nidaros should keep all the baggage he had come with. A lodging was got for him; it had a window, so that he could read his Hours; and for his victuals there was brought him a little bread and one other dish and a little small ale to wash it down; by night he had fetters on his feet; his feet swelled up, and the scurvy flew to his body. Icelanders were always coming to the window and talking with him; many men brought him food and drink, so that he had no lack for that. This was told the canons, and they put iron spikes outside against the window, so that none should be able to talk with him. The woman named Thurid, daughter of Arni, by whom he had had a boy Arni, often came to the window to him and brought him somewhat, as best she could, for food or comfort to him.

166

26. Now, when he was in these straits, many looked on him with eyes of compassion and showed him in word or deed some solace. The canons were as fierce towards him as ever; and, that he could have any exculpation from his charges, — that was not a thing to be heard of. Once it befell that he had got leave to go into the archbishop’s lodging where he lay in his sickness, though this was at first without the chapter’s knowledge. As soon as Laurence had come into the lodging with the fetters on his feet, the spies and eavesdroppers of the Chapter were ware of it; then he was haled out and not dealt with gently. The archbishop asked what that brawling was in the lodging; he was told

that Laurence had come into the room and would have talked with him, and was in fetters, and had then been dragged out violently.

167

Then, with a heavy sigh, said the archbishop, 'God requite him for the heavy dealing he has to endure of his adversaries; and this he suffers for the stout service he did us. But what will it serve him to meet us here where the pang is only doubled by our looking in each other's face? in me he will see sickness and sorrow, I misery in him.'

168

Then answered a servant of the archbishop, 'It seems heaviest of all to him, that he is told this is thy doing that he is so sore dealt with; and that this is all done by thy bidding.'

169

Then said the archbishop, 'Why will folk say so? That is not my bidding a whit. Thou mayest know, that when we fell on this sickness, the canons stopped all authority from us in spiritual as in temporal matters; and so little do we appoint or rule aught, that we do not even manage our daily food and drink: and they are fiercer than that to all those who stood on our side when we had to withstand them in law-suits. Now it is plain that God forbids not that things stay thus a while; but let Laurence be told to bear him as manfully as he may; for if he keeps alive there is hope that God may make manifest which side has stood more in the right.'

170

This was told Laurence, and he got much comfort of the archbishop's words. Now the canons kept on Laurence stronger ward than ever, so that he could never stir or get out.

171

27. All Laurence's goods were seized, as we said, and taken up into the archbishop's house; and the books which he had were filched. It was done craftily, thus; various priests from Iceland, wintering then at Thronðhjem, claimed them for their own. All winter was Laurence

thus in prison, and it was God's mercy that he stayed alive, and past all nature that his health broke not.

172

April 10, 1309

173

In spring, four nights before the feast of Tiburtius and Valerian, Archbishop Jorund departed this life. Then Eilff, whom we noticed before, was chosen archbishop; a man of good life.

174

Jan 25.

175

In Iceland, where there was much lamenting, the news was that Skálholt Church was burnt on the eve of Paul's Day, as swiftly as men swallow meat before Jan. 25. drinking. There was neither ember nor charcoal, for that fire came down from heaven. Then died in Iceland Hôskuld, the abbot of Thingeyri, and many priests; also Sir Gamli, at Hôskul Stad, a goodly preacher, who had power over priest and laymen, and a good yeoman. That was called the Deadly Spring. Then was also Lord Kolbein Bjamason slain by Charlemagne and Thorstein. In Norway was slain Ogmund 'Ungin-dance.' There was war in Norway from the foray of Eirek duke of the Swedes. Lord Bishop Ami voyaged out after the church fire.

176

28. Now to tell how the chapter put Laurence in chains on a trader, and sent a letter out with him to Bishop Jorund. He was stripped of all his goods, besides that which he prized dearest — his books with the holy Church law in them: and these were filched. They put to sea, the voyage prospered, and they landed safe and sound at Gâseyri. The traders, when they got to sea, straightway smote the fetters off Laurence, saying it was not the custom to carry folk in gaol or durance over the high seas. The canon's message was speedily delivered to Bishop Jorund, wherein they sent Sir Laurence to be under his jurisdiction, and told the way in which they imagined that they had

received evidence in his case; as was recorded above. Laurence came home to Holar; and when he went into the lodging where the bishop was, he fell on his knees. But the bishop stood up opposite him, and bade him sit by him, and so he sat down at the dinner-table. The bishop was most cordial to him, and bade Sir Laurence sleep there three nights. He did so; and when they were past, the bishop had Laurence called into the vestry with some priests; then he made him read out the ordinance of the archbishop-elect and likewise of the canons. Then Laurence asked the bishop how it was to go with his case.

177

‘Because of the doings of the Chapter I dare not let thee chant mass again; but I tell thee, that thou shalt go, for all I care, freely over Iceland, whither thou wilt; likewise in Skálholt See, if thou likest to come down there, or in the monasteries. Also thou canst do much service by educating and teaching, a matter wherein thou canst do well.’

178

‘Nought,’ said Laurence, ‘seems to me so hard as this, that I may not have the mass service.’

179

‘That thou gettest not,’ said the bishop, and sprang up and left the lodging.

180

Next night Laurence was at Holar and a strange dream came to him. He thought he was standing up beyond the choir lectern, and held a holy wafer high up, as the priest holds it at mass; on this wafer was marked *Alpha* and *Omega*. A priest had come south thither over the fell, old, but full of precious lore. Next morning they two were reading the services together. Laurence told him his dream.

181

The priest said, ‘In the spot where thou wentest up beyond the lectern here at Holar, there shalt thou be set and appointed over that choir of clergy that is here at Holar. Thou heldest up the wafer; thereby shalt

thou have the highest authority and ministration in thy hand. Also there was marked on it Alpha and Omega; which is, being interpreted, the beginning and the end; even as thou keptest school here and stayedst here in the beginning of thy life, so shall the days of thy life end here also, with thee set and established in highest authority.'

182

'Peace, peace, my priest,' said Laurence, 'for now I am so beset and come so low, that my adversaries may well think that I shall never become one high in honour: and so to some other man must this dream belong.'

183

Then Laurence went west over Vatn Pass, where Gudmund was consecrated abbot at Thingeyri into the benefice of Hoskuld his mother's brother. Laurence came there, and asked to teach the friars or clergy. But Abbot Gudmund durst not then receive him; for it was reported to have been said by Bishop Jorund that he did not wish Laurence to be in the north country in Holar See. Thence he went to his friend, Sir Haflidi Steinsson, at Breidabolstad in Vestrhof. Sir Haflidi went out to meet Sir Laurence and received him with open arms, and had hangings put in his room, and seated him next himself, and treated him as handsomely as a bishop. Then Sir Haflidi's men asked why he made so much of this fellow Laurence, considering the deep disfavour he was in with Bishop Jorund.

184

Then answered Sir Haflidi, so loud that all heard, 'My sons, and many else, are to bear in mind that this hook-nose who sits by me, Laurence, on whom all men look down, shall be bishop at Hôlar.'

185

In many ways Sir Haflidi was a prophet. Thence Laurence went south over the country. Abbot Thorlâk asked him east to Ver, to teach there. He accepted, and was there twelve months; keeping school and 1309-1310 teaching many clergy and brethren.

186

There he taught a poor scholar, whom Abbot Thorlâk was helping, called Runôlf. Sir Hafliði gave him a school nickname, saying that he was to be called ‘Grandam’; and so thenceforth he was. Afterwards he was to the fore and a good scholar.

187

29. In that year it befell that Arni Helgason came with much authority, given him by King Hâkon, and church timber withal, wherewith the church was to be built in Skálholt. Then came out the Pope’s bull about the Jerusalem gift. Then was the slaying in battle of Charlemagne, and Thorstein, and of Orm. Much smallpox overran all Iceland, and many young men died. Next year it befell that there was an ecclesiastical council at Vienne in France.

188

That next year Laurence was at Ver in Thykkvabaer, and taught there: but then came news south from Hôlar that the Chapter were ill pleased at Laurence’ welcome, and thought it beseemed him to stay under penance.

189

1311

190

Then Abbot Thorlâk dared not keep him. Then Hall Sigurdsson asked him to Dal under Eyja Fell. Sigurd ‘Seal-tar’ his father and Laurence had been good friends of old in Eyja Firth. Then Laurence went to Hall in Dal; he stayed winter there, but in spring he was minded to depart thence, for his and Hall’s way of life were not the same. Then Laurence was sore concerned where he should betake himself. And one morning in spring, as Laurence lay in his bed he was pondering deeply, chiefly about where he should settle or go for help. Then a light slumber seemed to glide upon him, and a man to come into the lodging where he lay, clad as a clerk, and to come forward to the bed wherein he lay, and to speak thus:

191

‘Truly thou art sore straitened and in need; but I give thee counsel, which if thou keepest, there shall be a turn for the better in thy fortunes. Read daily the Hours of the Holy Spirit, and forget it not; and the compassion of the Holy Spirit shall comfort thee, and loose thy toil and trouble.’

192

And when this man had thus spoken, he went away from him. Laurence had no chance of asking aught, or who he was; for swiftly it passed by him, and swiftly he woke. He gave God thanks for the vision, and began to keep the Hours, and kept ever after to these Hours till the day of his death. A few nights after this came a letter to Laurence from the northern quarter, from Abbot Thorir of Munka-Thverâ, asking Laurence north to see him, to teach the brethren and clergy there, for twelve months at first; and for this he had Bishop Jorund’s leave. Then Laurence managed to get north, and came to Munka-Thverà, as we said, and Abbot Thorir and the brethren took kindly to him, and there he taught clergy and brethren.

193

30. In the summer the events were: — Lord Christopher went abroad, also Lord Ivarr ‘holm’. Queen Euphemia died. Our Lord Pope’s missives came to Norway.

194

1312

195

That year died Lord Thôrd and Lord Lopt. The winter after died the worshipful Lord Jorund, bishop at Holar, on St. Bridget’s Day; he had then been bishop forty-six years.

196

Feb 1, 1313

197

He set up two monasteries, at Modruvellir and at Stad in Reynisnes. He had the church at Holar built up, and decked it with bells and furniture, and enriched the foundation with lands and goods, gold and

refined silver, and other fair treasures, which shall be seen till Iceland is dwelt in no more. It is not to be forgotten what happened when Laurence heard that Bishop Jorund was dead and gone. He was there in the monks' room at Thverâ, when all the bells were rung for a requiem. When a message of the news came from Holar, Laurence, like the rest, started up hastily, and with the speed of his uprising he got the ailment which never left him till his dying day; it was an injury in the small guts: this he himself testified unto a man whom he trusted. Lord Bishop Jorund ere he died, appointed to Sir Thorstein Illugason, called 'Notchstone,' the officary of the church of Holar. But Sir Kodran Hranason of Grenjadarstad claimed to be Bishop Jorund's coadjutor, being appointed so by Archbishop Eilif. And whereas Sir Kodran had more backing, and most people were minded to speak and do according to his will, he took all authority in spiritual things in Holar See. Laurence was at Munka-Thverâ through the winter, and many prospered greatly under his teaching. Next spring came Sir Kodran to Munka-Thverâ, where he was greeted like a bishop. Next day Sir Kodran called, unto him many learned men, and showed them the letters which the archbishop had given out to him, making him coadjutor of Bishop Jorund when he was declared incapable and worn with age. But this declaration had been false, because as far as capacity or infirmity went, Bishop Jorund, old as he was if reckoned by years, was well able to keep all his authority. And after the reading out of the letter — Sir Kodran had it read out — he reeled off a long speech, asking what people thought; which of them had the right to be Official, — Sir Thorstein, whom Bishop Jorund had appointed, or he; he himself, he thought, was the better man because of the letter's the archbishop had given him. Straightway all leapt up with one voice saying, that his was the greater authority, because of what he had from the archbishop; while Sir Thorstein only had the word of Bishop Jorund. Sir Laurence was in there, sitting outermost of the priests.

Then said Sir Kodran. ‘How thinkest thou, Laurence? Thou knowest well the Canon Law; tell us what the law seems to thee to say: which of us two, Sir Thorstein or I, has the right to be Official in the church of Holar as things stand?’

199

Sir Laurence answered, ‘Sir Kodran, why ask you such a thing? Nay, go home to Holar, and let the Canon Law-books tell you; for their plain pronouncement is this: — to me the case is clear that you, Sir Kodran, were appointed by the archbishop to be coadjutor of Bishop Jorund, since he was worn with age — while he lived; but when he departed from this world, there in this world was an end of his authority; likewise, by the death of the bishop, your authority is also dead and done with. But inasmuch as he had his sound senses, when he appointed to Sir Thorstein the officialty and authority in spiritual things over Holar bishopric, therefore my decision is, that that appointment has a right to stand, which he made in his last days.

200

At this speech of Laurence Sir Kodran so chafed and raged, that he said thus, openly, ‘Get thee out, foul forger! Thou shalt not be judge here!’

201

‘I can do this,’ said Laurence, ‘I can leave your presence; but the way to adjudicate between honourable priests, is the way I declare in this case.’

202

Such also was the archbishop’s decision, when he heard that Sir Thorstein and not Sir Kodran had the right to the officialty. Sir Laurence might never come into Sir Kodran’s sight while he was at Munka-Thvera; and so he asked Abbot Thorir to let him depart thence. Then Sir Laurence went west to Thingeyri, and joyfully Lord Abbot Gudmund welcomed him. He set up school there, and there taught Abbot Gudmund and many others. There was a deacon there, called Egil, son of Ejyolf the goldsmith and Thorgerd daughter of Egil; on this man Laurence spent all his pains in teaching him Latin; the man knew well how to turn it into profit, and became a ripe scholar and fine

versifier. Many others Laurence taught, of whom these got on best: Thord son of speaker Gudmund; a poor lad named Olaf Hjaltason; he taught him to be a good scholar, and he was afterwards schoolmaster at Holar. Sir Haflidi at Breidabldstad also put under him his son, named Einar, then ten years old. Sir Haflidi went thence to Holar, when Bishop Audun came to Iceland, and stayed with his daughter's son at Holar while Audun was bishop; for Sir Haflidi and Bishop Audun were the fastest of friends.

203

31. Now to tell how in the next summer after Lord Bishop Jorund departed, Sir Thorstein Illugason and Snjolf Sumarlidason went abroad with the news of Bishop Jorund's death. Then Audun the Red was chosen bishop of Holar; he was chief of the Chapter, and had long been treasurer of king Hâkon, and best beloved of all the canons by the king. Many said that they chose Audun bishop of Holar in Iceland, because they thought they would get no advancement from the king while Audun was by, as he had the king's ear most. He was consecrated bishop on St. Catherine's Day. He had long had the church in the north at Hâlogaland, called the Church at Thrândarnes. He was a leading man, rich in substance. The yeoman Clement was the husband of his daughter Ôlof. She had before had for husband Thorstein a yeoman, whose sons by her were Red Eystein and Red Thorberg; and the son of the yeoman Klemet and Ôlof was called Vigleik.

204

In that year there was a wreck of the merchant-ship *Uxi* [Ox], at Eyri. Then arose a fray between the Eastmen and Gizur 'Flaw,' so that they beat him. That was a hard winter, in which Bishop Jorund departed: that winter was called the 'horse-death' winter. In the next year, when Bishop Audun was consecrated, Pope Clement died. Then the Emperor was betrayed on Easter-day with this treason, that when he had taken the Lord's body, poison was put into the chalice whereof he drank, and thus he came by his death. Then Sir Snjolf and Sir Thorstein came out in the summer with the Pope's ordinance to pay him tithes of all

Church property. They were also appointed by Lord Bishop Audun officers over all Holar See, the lord bishop wintering in Norway.

205

32. Next year, in the summer, came Bishop Audun out to Iceland, landing at Seleyri. He rode the sand north to Holar, where all the chief priests were present. He was received at the bishop's place with little show.

206

1314

207

He was very stiff with riding, being an old man. Sir Kodran and Sir Snjólf did nothing but mock him; scant heed he paid to it. He had beams brought north from Eyri, whereof he had a timber hall built at Holar. In autumn Bishop Audun visited over the western district, and consecrated the church at Thingeyri. Laurence was there at the time; Audun paid no heed to him then, and so of course Laurence gave himself little pains for him. Many complaints were lodged before Bishop Audun, which were useless because he did not know the ways of the country. And when he came home from his visitation, he drove away Skuli who was steward, and seized all his goods. In the winter arose great quarrelling and discord between Sir Kodran and Sir Snjólf on the one side, and Lord Bishop Audun on the other. They were both in league against him and appealed at first to the archbishop. Lord Bishop Audun took Grenjadarstad from Sir Kodran. Snjólf submitted to the bishop, and received the living of Grenjadarstad.

208

As soon as the lord bishop came home from his visitation, he inquired where the relics of the good Bishop Gudmund were like to be; for they had been so neglected before, that people knew not where they were likely to be. Digging was first done inside the choir, but they were not found there — only some other relics in a coffin, just as Bishop Jorund had had them done up when he built the new church. Then the smith, Kolli Helgason, was sent for: for long he would not come, being

somewhat out with the lord bishop. Later, though, he came, being more admonished to it by what was due to Bishop Gudmund, than by the bidding of Bishop Audun. Then said Kolli, that it was of no avail to look in the choir; he told them to break up the floor in the nave. He marked the spot so clearly, that the coffin was found where he said, and he opened it. Therein were found the bishop's remains, and all done up just as Bishop Jorund had told him. A leg was to be seen broken, with a clean clout wrapped round it; on the leg were huge knobs, as was to be looked for according as is told in the Life of Gudmund, namely that he broke his leg when lying off Strand, when he was a scholar with Ingimund his kinsman. Then Bishop Audun was called, and he was very glad thereat, and had then a new coffin made, and the relics of blessed Bishop Gudmund put in it. Afterwards Lord Bishop Audun had it done up beautifully with a grating, and had a great cross put before it inside the church. Then straightway came a great gathering to the church, and many prayers were made over all Iceland, and there were many goodly miracles. It was a great good chance for Bishop Audun that he was the first bishop of Hôlar to take the relics of the blessed Bishop Gudmund out of the ground; by whose help his renown and report have waxed ever since, beyond all those bishops of Hôlar that came after, even until now. Then straightway, throughout the days of Bishop Audun, there was a mighty holiday on Gudmund's Day; the bishop himself sang services and masses for his soul, and honoured him in all things to the foremost of his power. Lord Audun did this from the goodwill which God breathed into his breast, and somewhat also from the prompting of king Hâkon when he parted with him. But before Bishop Audun came there was no remembrance kept of him, save that a mass was said for his soul, even as for the rest of the bishops of Hôlar: but there was no holiday, for men knew not where were his relics and his resting-place.

Till Bishop Audun came there was no observance of the day of translation of holy Bishop John of Hôlar: hours only were chanted, but

it was not kept holiday. Lord Bishop Audun stopped this, so that there were orders over all Hôlar See to keep it sacred by law, and to chant twice inside the church. By things like this it could be seen what a mighty ruler Bishop Audun was. He had brought to Iceland with him a stone-mason, and south of the church in Rafta Slope he found a red rock, and this he had broken up, brought home and hewn, and had a stone oven made in the wooden hall (as is done in Norway) to carry out the smoke while he was sitting himself within. Also he had the high altar built of stone, and a hollow therein with an iron door before it, so that the treasures of the church could be in ward there, safe from fire and everything; likewise he had made all the steps which are to be seen in the church, and the pillars in the choir; and had the ceiling painted, and the ceiling put over the high altar, where coffins and other rubbish had been hitherto. Also he contributed good furniture and a fine cope called *Skarmande*. He had the bishop's lodging done up in a fashion seldom seen in so poor a country, and a pretty penny this repairing cost the church. Notable above all was his great hospitality: for though his adversaries were contending with him, and his servants announced it was time to go to table, thus he spoke to his foes: 'Go to table and to God's gifts; be not wroth with the meat, though ye be wroth with me.' Thus he often prevailed over his adversaries, so that after the merry and good cheer which he dealt them, they yielded everything into his power. All his service he went through in goodly style. He had a voice so beautiful, loud, and clear, that every one was ravished to hear his chanting. He was a mighty man in prayer, for he sang a third of the Psalms of Our Lady which holy Archbishop Anselm had writ in Latin. He kept a water-fast before all the days of the apostles and St. Mary's Days, and before many bishops' days. He kept all the Hours through Lent and Advent; but not daily, save on the highest of high-days.

210

33. On St. Gregory's Day, the priests of most note in Holar See assembled to Holar.

211

March 12 1316.

212

The bishop had the mass stopped when it had got as far as the Gospel; for the bishop accounted Kodran excommunicated. This was accounted his offence, that he had let the brethren in Môdruvellir have authority in temporal things; the bishop thought that they had squandered a deal of money since the death of Bishop Jorund, and he wanted Kodran to pay it back to the church of Holar. Next, Kodran had taken on him to do the duty of the Official; the third offence he accounted to be his conspiracy against himself. At this time all the priests were leagued in opposition to him, except Sir Haflidi of Breidabldstad; the bishop gave him good gifts, and he parted on ill terms with Kodran. The goodwill which Bishop Audun showed to the foremost priests met with ill requital; for he gave dispensations to their sons, having authority thereto from the Pope. He gave dispensation among the following: — Einar Haflidason, Paul Thorsteinsson, Thorstein Hallsson, Thormod Thorkelsson. These were the foremost men in Holar See for scholarship and success. He also gave it to John Kodransson, who was a leading man and priest of note, because of his shrewdness and substance.

213

In that year John the Twenty-second was made Pope. Bishop Arni went to Greenland. Then died Ingjald bishop of Hamar. In the year after that in which Bishop Audun came to Iceland much happened.

214

1315

215

At Môdruvellir, in the Horg Valley, the convent and church with all the bells and church furniture were burnt. The convent in 'Nidarholm was also burnt. Then Lord Bishop Audun also took the abbey away from Abbot Thdrir, at Múnka-Thverà. Then also arose a disagreement between Bishop Audun and Gudmund abbot at Thingeyri. The

beginning thereof was, that Eyjolf, a yeoman in Forsaela-dale, told Bishop Audun that the alms which Karl the rich had given, being worth seven hundred and twenty ells of wool, which ought to be at Breidabdlstad, in Vestrhof, and which he had given for distribution among the paupers to whom the alms were due, had been taken off by Thorstein Hjâlmsson, when he went from Breidabdlstad to Thingeyri; and that these seven hundred and twenty ells had never come back to Breidabdlstad. Lord Bishop Audun bade Sir Haflidi claim back these alms for the church at Breidabdlstad. Sir Haflidi was loath unto this, for he was prebendary at Thingeyri and loved the church there well; still he did the bishop's bidding. And upon witness and inquiry made, the bishop decided that the property which Karl the rich had given at the first should be restored. Secondly, Abbot Gudmund and the brethren laid a complaint against the church of Holar about the bishop's tithes namely, that John, first bishop of Holar, had given all the bishop's tithes, west of Vatndale river, to Thingeyri Convent when he founded it, to help it. For this reason Abbot Gudmund appealed to the archbishop. Sir Laurence composed this appeal in Latin, and sided with the abbot in all his doings.

216

1317

217

This same year at the beginning of Lent, Laurence and his son Ami took monk's vows; Arni had come to his father two years since, and Laurence had him taught.

218

In Lent Laurence was consecrated monk, as well as Arni his son, by Abbot Gudmund. Then also Berg Sokkason joined the brotherhood. Laurence had known him of old at Mûnka-Thverâ, when he set himself to learn of Laurence: he was the most accomplished scholar, a splendid chanter, and a great orator; so that he composed many histories of the saints very eloquently in Northern speech. Brother Berg and Laurence loved one another with the love of their hearts; for all whom he saw

were willing to learn good, and use their learning for good, Laurence loved.

219

Brother Laurence observed well the rules of St. Benedict, under whom he had vowed himself, so as to be an ensample for many. He was not much for gadding abroad, for he never left his cloister unless he was bidden by his superior, or 'for strong urgency. The times of silence he kept carefully: then, just as in the night when it was 'utmost silence,' he never said a word, either in Latin or Northern speech; and between these times he spoke mostly Latin, as in church and congregation. Lowly and obedient he was to his superior; he would never sit down anywhere but in the congregation; though the abbot asked him, he would excuse himself, and beg that the other monks should sit. His sole business was to read, teach, and study books. He bestowed all pains, teaching Arni Latin and handwriting; the lad became a most accomplished scholar, and wrote very finely, and was a versifier. It could be truly said that a convent that was made up of such monks as were then at Thingeyri, was a fine one.

220

34. Egil Eyjulfsson, deacon, was in this year named above consecrated priest by Bishop Audun, and then he was first appointed schoolmaster at Hôlar. Their parting seemed a mighty matter to Laurence, for he had formed the lovingest regard for him. In the summer Gudmund, abbot at Thingeyri, went abroad, and stayed abroad two years. The archbishop did nothing about his suit with Bishop Audun, not wishing to do aught till Audun came to answer for himself. In autumn Bishop Audun visited over the Western district. And as he rode from Breidabôlstad to Thingeyri, the brethren barred the convent in the face of Bishop Audun, and made no procession to meet him. Meat was prepared for his people, and also for himself, but no ale. Sir Hafliði had his own ale brought out, and Audun and his people drank this. Brother Bjorn Thorsteinsson was prior over the convent and establishment. Many yeomen had come down over Vatn-dale to defend the convent

from the bishop, if he thought of assaulting it; but little liking showed he or any of his men for doing so.

221

1319

222

Next year it came to pass that King Hâkon Magnússon, king of Norway, died. In Sweden also it befell that King Birgir starved in prison his two brothers, Duke Eirík the long and Valdimar: the wife of Eirík was Ingibjorg, the daughter of King Hâkon; she was, afterwards called the duchess. In the same year died Sir Haflidi of Breidabólstað, a man of mark, sometime chaplain of King Eirík, and afterwards for long steward at Hôlar and Thingeyri. Then died Sir Kodran Ranason in Norway.

223

Sir Egil had leave of Lord Bishop Audun, and had thought to go to Norway in the ship that was at Seleyri, in which same ship Sir Grim Ôfeigsson was to have gone with business of Lord Bishop Audun; but that ship was weather-beaten back. Sir Egil was now still at Hôlar, and the bishop took him utterly into his love. Then in the summer came a writ summoning out both bishops of Iceland, both lawmen, Lord Ketil Thorkelsson, six officers of the king, and six of the chief yeomen. Lord Grim Thorstein took the jurisdiction, and Erlend the yeoman from Upsir in Svarfadar-dale had the jurisdiction over the Northern quarter.

224

Dec 23

225

Then was destroyed the church in Skalholt in winter, just before Thorlák's Day. Magnúus Eiríksson, son of King Hakon's daughter, was chosen king over Norway, Sweden, and Gotland. Lord Erlend Vidkunsson was Regent over all the kingdom of Norway, Lord Archbishop Eilíff and all the mightiest lords in Norway consenting, King Magnúus being three years old. Next summer Lord Bishop Audun

made ready to journey abroad from Gdseyri, was driven back, and landed at Hüsavfk, Sir Egil being then still with him. He stayed the winter at home at Holar.

226

35. In autumn Sir Egil was mediator to reconcile Bishop Audun and brother Laurence, putting it clearly before the bishop that a man like Laurence was a tower of strength to him. Bishop Audun sent Sir Egil west to Thingeyri, and brother Laurence rode to Holar with him; and they met, and the bishop received him worthily, granting him his friendship; whereunto brother Laurence granted his obedience in return; and was to teach the son of the lord bishop's daughter, named Eystein. This youth went with brother Laurence, who taught him; and he afterwards became a man of mark, and for a long time had St. Mary's Church in Throndhjem, and was called Eystein the 'Red.' Through the winter and spring there was disquiet in Hôlar See; for, because of the slanders of wicked men, it was said against Bishop Audun that the tithe would have to be paid by property assessed at a hundred and twenty ells and upwards. The vagabonds would not brook this, and banded together over Skaga Firth, and raised a gang. They laid wait for the bishop in Hôfdahôlar, and there was a danger that they might have taken him and laid hands upon him, if Rafn Jônsson from Glaumbaer and many priests had not yielded the promise that thenceforth the tithes should be imposed and arranged as of old, and that the paupers should not receive a share from property worth less than six hundred ells.

227

In the winter people fared very hard; far and wide was the deep-sea ice, and the weather was very bitter. In the spring Lord Bishop Audun set his face against the vow that had been made on Easter-day to the sainted John bishop of Holar, namely, that every yeoman in Skaga Firth between the lava-fields who was liable to dues, should give a clipped sheepskin, wherewith to buy a graven image, to be made for the sainted John bishop of Holar; this the yeoman Rafn Jonsson had to

prevent being done. The weather took a turn for the better in this way: — On Easter-day, before high mass, when the shrine was brought out, the north wind straightway dropped dead; and after high mass it arose from the south, and in evening, at evensong a thaw came and kept up till the ice and snow were all gone. And through the spring there was good grass, and the sea-ice drifted away. Also there was contention between Bishop Audun and Sir Snjôlf, from whom he took Grenjadarstad, the charge being that he would not take the clerk whom the bishop ordained to that place. The bishop exacted an oath that seven clerks should be bound to be kept at Grenjadarstad. Many other charges the bishop had against Snjolf; the end was that the bishop laid on him the uttermost ban, depriving him of all communion with Christian men. Snjolf heeded this not a whit, but went to Norway.

228

Àrni, bishop of Skálholt, had sailed in the summer before to Norway, and died in Norway in the winter. Orm Thorsteinsson was bishop-elect of Skálholt. In the spring 1320 just spoken of, the ship *Shâk* [*Chess*] touched East Firth and broke on the ice. Abbot Thôrd and Berg Jónsson were on board, and all hands reached land sorely distressed. The aforesaid Berg was on his way with letters to Bishop Audun. Straightway the bishop made Berg start off and sent him south to Eyri to take ship there, and this was done. In summer, at the moot, the laymen from the Northern quarter leagued in the resolve to suffer no innovation at the hand of Bishop Audun. After the moot Lord Grim and many men of mark rode to Hôlar and parleyed with Bishop Audun; the bishop was not softened at their words, and they against whom he had complaints before submitted unto him; and thus they parted.

229

36. In summer Bishop Audun made ready and departed from Hôlar with his company, and Sir Egil went with him. Sir Thorstein Illugason he left for his Official. In the same ship was also Orm, bishop-elect of Skálholt. They put to sea, and had a fair voyage, and reached Norway. Lord Bishop Audun went north to Throndhjem, and there met

Archbishop Eilif, who received him kindly; there he wintered. Now it is to be recorded that Lord Ketil Thorláksson came to Iceland with writs from the king. The land was then sworn in to King Magnus. Then came to Norway Lord Gudmund, abbot from Thingeyri, and Sir John Kodransson, who was at Hólar through the winter and kept school there.

230

Lord Bishop Audun abode in Throndhjem and feasted deep at Yule; not till far past Yule was it over. At his banquet also the archbishop stayed some days; but the canons continually. Early in Yule Lord Audun took gout; first it came on the leg at the knee, and then the pain struck up into the body. Leeches were called, all counsel sought, and it grew worse and worse. So stout a fellow was he, that he sat up with his mates, making them as merry as though he had not a pang. And when he saw how it would be with him, he called the archbishop and all the chief men, bidding them to his banquet still. And, after the pledging of Mary, he spoke nobly, and thanked God and Mary his sweet mother for all the rich estate and fair fortune which God had given to him, so unworthy of this world; begging all men nigh him there to forgive him and pray God for him, and saying out that within a few days he would go forth from the world. First he gave to the archbishop, to the canons, and to all the foremost men who had gathered there to banquet, the goodliest gifts; entreating them also, that three nights thence, however it went with his life, they should hold like feast and revel. Then all took leave of him, and he went away leaning on somebody. Then he took to his bed and made all his dispositions, choosing to rest in St. Mary's Church there in the town, seeing that he might not lie in that Mary's Church where he was bishop, at Hólar in Iceland. And after he was anointed, the archbishop came to him and asked him who in Iceland was fitted best to be bishop at Hólar, when he was gone.

231

Then Bishop Audun answered, 'In Holar See there are many fine clergy; but before God I will answer for this, that no man seems to us better fitted to be bishop than brother Laurence at Thingeyri. This can we make good for many reasons. And first, because he has given himself to God, and served well and devoutly under the holy rule of St. Benedict; this was told us for truth when we were in Iceland. Further, he is the best scholar, and well skilled in Canon Law. Also he is bold and trusty in all business that concerns law-suits; and he would never let the rights which belong to Holy Church be wrested from her hand; for the men of North Iceland need this — to have a bishop over them who is both a great scholar and a firm enough hand to chastise all the perverseness and disobedience in that place.'

232

'Thou knewest,' the archbishop said, 'how he withstood us both, when he was with Archbishop Jorund, and read the writ of ban upon us twain.'

233

Lord Audun replied, 'Doth not the need of Holy Church that men like this should be chosen to be governors and bishops, count to thee for more than certain offences done against us? this also is most right and becoming before God, that if in this and that we have transgressed against him, we should hereby redress it. Laurence is not guilty for doing his master's bidding.'

234

So heartily did Audun speak about this matter, that he wept; and all that were there praised his speaking.

235

Jan 21, 1322

236

And when Bishop Audun had received all God's sacrament, he died, on the second day of St. Agnes, with great glory and high report; and his resting-place is in St. Mary's Church in Thronthjem. His departure was observed with the utmost honour and worship. His heirs increased

the banquet which he had kept up in his lifetime, and bade guests afresh, and turned it into a funeral feast. It has been the common speech of men, that no man of all the Norse bishops was ever such a prince in Iceland in all manner of magnificence, as Bishop Audun.

237

37. Now to tell how after a little while had gone by, the Archbishop summoned the Chapter, and dealt with them about the choice of a bishop to the church of Hôlar. Archbishop Eilff would have nothing but the choice of brother Laurence for bishop Hôlar, even as Bishop Audun had pointed out. By God's will it was so decided, that Archbishop Eilff chose and elected brother Laurence bishop at Hôlar, all the canons consenting. This election was published in the chancel, Christ Church, in Nidarôs, a *Te Deum* being first chanted, and bells rung.

238

Before this it befell that Orm Thorsteinsson, bishop-elect to Skallholt, died ere he was consecrated. Then Orm Steinsson was chosen bishop in Skalholt, and was loath to be; and so he made his pilgrimage to the threshold of the apostles Peter and Paul, and died soon after. After this 'Skiff' Grim was chosen, who before that was abbot at Holm in Nidaros. He was consecrated bishop in Skálholt, and was bishop three months, and spent thirty-six thousand ells value, the property of the church in Skálholt; he died in Hogn, when the traders were lying by for a wind. After that Bishop John Halldorsson was chosen and consecrated to Skálholt; he was of the Dominican Order, a great scholar, and noble preacher; he had been long abroad studying in Bologna and at Paris in France. While this was passing in Norway, people in Iceland were unaware of how things had gone there. At the moot, a ship, driven back, came to Eyri. Among people of note therein was the Lady Mâlfrid. Only then did it get abroad that bishops were chosen for Iceland; Bishop John to Skálholt, and brother Laurence to Hôlar. People could not think who this Laurence could be, not believing at first that brother Laurence from Thingeyri could be elected.

239

1322

240

Now it must be told how this summer, a little after the moot, it came to pass, that Abbot Gudmund from Thingeyri was asked by the Lady Gudnin, daughter of Thorstein, then dwelling at Holtastad in Langdale, to a friendly feast; and with Abbot Gudmund went the two brethren, brother Bjorn and brother Laurence. And when he and they were riding home, and had passed over Blanda, a man named Thorvard, and nicknamed 'Bishop,' met them; he told them of the arrival of Bishop Audun's ship, and of his death. Abbot Gudmund asked what people said about who was chosen bishop to Holar. Thorvard said that he was called Laurence. Now they had not yet heard of the ship's arrival or the news. And when the man had left them, brother Bjorn said to Laurence, 'Brother Laurence, wilt not thou be the bishop-elect?'

241

He answered, 'Flout me not; it seems to me likelier that the canons in Norway have so plucked me down from my degree, as many know, that I have not the least hope of their ordaining authority unto me.'

242

And when they came home to Thingeyri, within two days after that, a letter came from the Lady Mâlfrid to brother Laurence, saying that she had been there in Christ Church in Norway, that he was elected bishop at Holar, and that this had been published in the chancel. He could not now hide from himself the truth of the stories that tallied. He was deeply moved about this matter, thanking God and his sweet mother Mary for all the gifts vouchsafed unto him. He kept his seat in the choir and cloister.

243

Aug 3

244

In summer on the latter St. Ôlafs Day, Sir Egil Eyjdlfsson came with the archbishop's decree; he had entered the country a few days before on

the ship that put in at Gâseyri. The decree was in this wise, there were two letters with hanging seals, and this was their tenor: one said that the archbishop remitted to him all the offences which he had done against the church of Nidaros, the Archbishop and the Chapter; giving this reason, to which the Canon Law testifies, that the entering of a cloister is like any other baptism, and so all that a man has done against God's laws is remitted to him as soon as he goes under the holy order. The sense of the other letter was, that the archbishop, with the counsel and enactment of all the canons, elected brother Laurence bishop at Hôlar, with all the state and glory which befits the rank and honour of a bishop; confirming his authority, that he might receive his consecration with all speed.

245

38. When this decree had been made and delivered, he and all with him thanked God for this gift and authority that was vouchsafed him; of this any man soever may be sure, that what elected this man Laurence was rather Divine mercy and the guidance of the Holy Spirit, than show, riches, or bribery; seeing that they who before were his chief adversaries chose him to this station; so that this was the breath of the Holy Spirit in their breasts, without aid of any of Laurence' friends or kin. This over, the lord bishop-elect wrote to Lord Ketil, who was then governor in Iceland, and he came to Thingeyri, and north to Sir Thorstein the Official. They all rode together, and the lord bishop-elect with them to Holar; where a feast was prepared for them.

246

Aug 10, 1322

247

On St. Laurence' Day the decree of the archbishop about the election of Laurence was announced from the choir by Lord Ketil Thorlâksson. Then the *Te Deum* was sung with the ringing of bells, and Lord Ketil and Sir Thorstein the Official led the lord bishop-elect to his seat. The lord bishop-elect and Lord Ketil parted in the friendliest fashion. The lord bishop-elect had an inspection of the goods of the church at Holar,

and for all manner of reasons it was very bare at his coming. God had shown before this in the spring that the coming of Laurence pleased him. For there was a whale drifted up on that estate of the church at Hôlar which is called Ness; this whale was both fine and large, fully thirty-eight thousand four hundred pounds weight, so that people could not - have had a better jetsam come just then upon the place. The lord bishop-elect took Skuli Ingason the priest back for steward at Holar; he had had it a long while in the days of Bishop Jorund, and was thought a good overseer: Sir Hafliði, when he was himself steward, trained him first. Solvi he made bailiff, and Gudrun, daughter of Skegg, his wife, he made stewardess. These two were the most experienced wardens, and they stayed as long as he was bishop. Over all the storehouses of the church he appointed those of ripe counsel, and declared before all men that he would have all the rules kept just as Bishop Jorund had them. The lord bishop-elect said he would not meddle with daily business, save with his cellar and wardrobe, and the governing of the clergy; and every gift of wadmal that came he made over to the poor.

248

Aug 15

249

On the first St. Mary's Day he preached, and gave handsomely to the stout fellows who had come to the monastery; then straightway the church and monastery seemed to rejoice at the coming of such a ruler. After St.

250

Mary's Day he rode north to Modruvellir. There were no brethren there, though Bishop Audun had made provision for priests there; brother Thorgeir in Lôgmanns Slope was a sort of vicar, and brother Thôrd at Vfdivellir in Skaga Firth, but brother Thorbjorn and brother Brand had gone home to Hôlar and died there. Holar Church, ever since the monastery was burnt, took all the rent from the foundation, and all the goods that belonged thereto; two priests were there with a

steward, and two deacons. In such a matter it could be seen how hard a task Lord Laurence had when he came into power; for he saw clearly that it thwarted God's laws for religious men to be out in the world like other secular priests; yet the lord bishop was loath to do aught to it till he met the archbishop. Thence he went to Munka-Thverâ, where there was lack of a head, Abbot Thorir being, as we said, deposed from his abbotship and away in Norway. The lord bishop-elect appointed Berg Sokkason from Thingeyri as a head of the Thverâ monastery, in temporal as in spiritual matters; and forthwith, then and there, brother Berg amended their ways unto goodness. Thence the lord bishop-elect went north to Grenjadarstad; here Sir John Kodransson held the living which had been appointed unto him by Sir Thorstein the Official. To him also the bishop-elect gave full powers until he should return from Norway. Then the lord bishop-elect rode home to Holar and wintered there. He made Ôlaf Hjaltason, who was deacon there, schoolmaster at home in the seat, and found for it scholars who came daily to school. Then straight he fell to taking count of men's ways of life in his See, clergy and laymen alike, admonishing them daily to quit the path of sin; and before he was bishop he had no bigger business than this. The church at Hvamm, in Vato-dale, owned two shares in the home-estate, the yeoman Finnbjôrn Sigurdarson owning the third. The church seemed to the bishop-elect to be in a sorry way, for the yeoman Finnbjôrn was managing both the church's share and his own. The lord bishop-elect found fault therewith, and desired to appoint some priest over the church's share, while Finnbjôrn should manage his own. But Finnbjôrn was loath. It came to this, that the lord bishop-elect dealt him an admonition to let it go, saying that, if he did not, he would proceed against him. Or else he offered to buy his share of him for its full worth. The end was, that by good men's counsel, yeoman Finnbjôrn sold his share in the estate for seven thousand two hundred ells of stuff, the lord bishop-elect wishing the church thus to have the estate free in its hands. He appointed over it his son, Egil Grimstunga, and helped him to move his household thither; and to the

Lady Gudrðn and the Lady Thurid he lent Hvamm until his return from Norway.

251

April 23, 1323

252

Early in spring the lord bishop-elect visited over the Western district, and was at Breidabôlstad, in Vestrhôp, with Sir Thorstein ‘Shardstone’ on the day of John bishop of Hôlar.

253

The winter and spring were then so hard that sheep were lost; still, on the day of John bishop of Hôlar, matters mended.

254

39. Lord Gudmund, abbot at Thingeyri, and the brethren spoke to the lord bishop-elect about the bishop’s tithe. He answered that he was not fully enough appointed to deal with it till he was consecrated bishop, and he invited the taking of umpires, by them on their own behalf, by himself on behalf of the church at Hôlar; and so it was settled between them. For the side of Hôlar church he chose Sir John Kodransson, while the abbot and brethren chose Lang-Orm, provost at West Firth, and holding the living of Holt in Onund Firth. Both sides were to accept these men’s award until the archbishop gave his own. They were over this arbitration while the bishop-elect was at Thingeyri, and their award was that the foundation and convent of Thingeyri should keep Hjalta Bank, which Bishop Jorund had assigned to Thingeyri long ago; but Bishop Audun had taken it from them and given it to the priest Sir Jôngeir, who abode there some years. This the abbot and friars thought a pitiful recompence for the tithe; but so it had to rest until the archbishop should make an end of the matter; and with this they parted.

255

In the summer the bishop-elect took ship in the *Krafs* [? *Scratch*] with Clement Atlason, yeoman, and the people he had with him. These men went with him, Sir Egil Eyjôlfsson, Sir Stephen, Athalbrand

Magnusson, Deacon Eirek the Red, and ship's crew. In the summer, till he embarked, the bishop-elect stayed at Modruvellir. A day or two before they put out, three ships came to Gâseyri, each a dinner's length after other, and all from Norway. Hallkel, yeoman at Ungland's-Bowl, was in one; Sigvaldi in the second, called the *Elftri*, and on the third ship, called the *Glod* [Embers], was Sir Snjôlf. The two first ships lay off Gâseyri in harbour to begin with; they had good wares for the north country. Sir Snjôlf and the bishop-elect met, and Snjôlf would make him no reverence. Awhile they talked, somewhat stiffly. At last the bishop-elect asked, 'Wilt thou give me the parting-kiss?'

256

Snjôlf answered, 'Laurence, kiss thee I will not; for, maybe, as time passes, thou wouldst call it a Judas-kiss.'

257

So they parted joylessly.

258

Sept 5

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40. Now to tell how yeoman Clement and the lord bishop-elect put forth from Gâseyri: this was on the feast-day of Abbot Bertin; they had a good wind north off Langness, and also eastwards over sea; a strong good breeze and keen weather. They were out only a little time and touched Hâlogaland, in the north, opposite Brunney. Where they were going was an inshore reef, but they saw where they had got to and launched a boat. But the trader dashed up on the skerry quicker than they thought; the ship split from under, and straightway the keel was down, and all the freight sank. The lord bishop-elect, all the women, and all the less fighting folk went into the boat; some got to land with spars, Sir Egil with the mast-tree. All the people reached land, save that one woman died on the spot, named Thordis, and known as 'Blossom-cheek.' The whole fund of money mostly perished instantly on the spot; yet a good deal was saved, for they dragged up the rolls and bales of wadmal and the casks of train-oil; and of dried fish there was none

on board. The lord bishop-elect reached land first, yet, as might be supposed, distressfully. He was no long time there before a freight-ship was got and hired for him to go south to Throndhjem. On board with him were Sir Egil and Laurence's son, brother Arni, and some of his servants, with deacon Athalbrand; Sir Stephen, however, whom he appointed to stay behind by the wreck, and have all the goods dragged up that could be found, wintered there with a few servants of the church at Holar. The lord bishop-elect came with his train to Throndhjem, and Lord Archbishop Eilff was there in the town. Laurence went up to the bishop's house, and with leave he entered, and fell down before the archbishop, craving forgiveness for his transgressions against him. Forthwith up got the archbishop's self, and lifted Laurence, bidding him welcome. 'All that is remitted already,' said the archbishop, 'as may be seen in the letter I sent to you. Also, if in any matter we have dealt amiss with you, we pray you forgive it us.'

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'That,' said Laurence, 'was only right.' The archbishop bade him tell him how he had fared since he left Iceland. The lord bishop-elect told him how all had befallen, shipwreck and all; also how he and his men had come without stores. This vexed the archbishop, but he invited him at his own charges, as well as his men, to eat with him in his archbishop's house. Gladly the lord bishop-elect accepted this; as it seemed best to close with the archbishop in the matter. Sir Arni, known as 'Wader,' was then steward at the Archbishop Eilif's house, being his sister's son. He was archbishop afterwards next to Archbishop Paul, and the bishop-elect's dearest friend. As we said, it came to pass that Laurence sat at table with the archbishop the winter through. Sir Egil sat on a steward's chair, and the others on the proper seats. The bishop-elect chose Stephen Hauksson for his cupbearer and servant, because he was an Iclander. Stephen was the greatest master in many crafts — goldsmith's work, carving, and draughtsmanship, and Laurence made him beautify the bowl of John bishop of Hôlar, which John got at Rome. This bowl had lain neglected at Hôlar until

then, but Laurence had it beautified, and himself wrote the Latin verses thereon now graven. There were many matters which the lord bishop-elect had before noted about all the knotty points that had come up in Hôlar See: he asked what the archbishop thought was the law upon these, for in all things he was fain to observe the law. There, with the archbishop, Laurence wintered, and the archbishop in all things did lovingly by him and his people. In the autumn of the summer in which Laurence sailed, there came to Skâlholt in Iceland Lord Bishop John Halldorsson.

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1323-4

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He performed the consecrations of both Sees: then were consecrated Sir Paul Thorsteinsson and Sir Ôlaf Hjaltason with many more consecrated priests from Hôlar diocese.

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1324

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41. Now must be told how Lord Archbishop Eilif summoned the bishops to him —

265

Lord Audfin, bishop of Bergen and Lord William, bishop of the Orkneys.

266

These came to Throndhjem on John the Baptist's Day. Lord Archbishop Eilif consecrated Laurence bishop with all the june pomp and honour which Holy Church keeps and observes in such cases; with the usual forms of law, the aforesaid bishops standing by. A little before this, in the spring, Sir Stephen had come south from Hâlogaland to Throndhjem on a trader with the goods of the church of Holar. Very soon after the consecration of Laurence to be bishop, brother Ingimund Skutuson laid a complaint against the church of Hôlar and Bishop Laurence, because provisions had all gone at Modruvellir and

all the brethren were driven away, while the church and bishop of Hôlar had laid hands on all the rents of the church of Modruvellir. Ingimund was then a brother at Elgisetr of the Order of St. Austin.

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To this complaint Laurence thus answered, 'All good people know that the monastery at Modruvellir had gone to pieces when I was bishop-elect; inasmuch as Bishop Audun had charged the brethren, that, all because of their foolish handling of the light which they had gone tipsily about with on the night they came from Gâseyri, the fire had struck up into the tapestries in the chancel, and some of it down into the chest of vestments; which last they opened, because there, as it seemed, the fire was most furious. Bishop Audun said he was not bound to have their monastery mended, since this damage had come from their own recklessness.'

268

The archbishop answered, 'You know well it is Canon Law, that any convent originally founded, is to stand, if there be no let or hindrance, for ever and ever. Further, if the rents and revenues of the church and monastery have been settled upon the Holar church, who else shall be bound to keep up the cloister, or have it built, if not the bishop of Hôlar? But let those brethren who have been clearly proved guilty of what you said, be thrust into the strictest monasteries. Also we will appoint judges-delegate out in Iceland, to give out our judgment about the said case.' Lord Laurence said this pleased him well; nor was any more done about this case at the time.

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42. Also Lord Abbot Gudmund had now written out to the archbishop about the tithe case. Brother Arni read out the whole process and evidence of Thingeyri monastery before the Archbishop and Chapter. The archbishop said he would fain also hear Bishop Laurence' answer. 'For,' he said, 'we were told, that when you were yourself in the monastery, it seemed to you law that the church of Thingeyri had a

right to the bishop's tithes; that is, according to what your son the young brother has told us.'

270

Laurence answered, 'Thy news, my Lord, is true, namely that when I was in the monastery at Thingeyri I pleaded as best I could that the monastery had a right to the tithes, according to the gift of St. John, first bishop of Hôlar, who founded the Thingeyri monastery. But though he was a good man, he could not give them for longer than his own life, or tie the hands of future bishops of Hôlar.'

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Brother Ami, his son, answered, 'What you said when you were at Thingeyri was, that there was a right to keep them, now that the two bishops after John had agreed with him and upheld the gift unalterably. Now, those two bishops after him upheld this; so that one can count up seven bishops after him throughout whose days the tithes remained with the Thingeyri monastery, right on until Bishop Jorund confiscated them in the days of Abbot Vermund.'

272

'Thanks, young brother,' said the archbishop, 'thou standest by thy own cloister. We beg you, Lord Laurence, and likewise enjoin you, to give the convent good terms, and suffer us a right to see to it.'

273

Bishop Laurence said, 'Will you confirm whatever agreement I and Abbot Gudmund, with the friars, make together?'

274

The archbishop said he would do that gladly. No more was done about the business.

275

43. It also happened now that Sir Egil asked and got Grenjadar living from the archbishop, thinking that it was really under his authority, though it had been lost by the carelessness of Bishop Audun. Bishop Laurence recompensed the archbishop in a way that pleased him well, for the entertainment of himself and his people. And when Lord

Laurence was ready to go, he took leave of the archbishop cheerily. The archbishop gave goodly gifts to Lord Laurence, and they parted with true loving-kindness. Lord Laurence went south to Bergen and took passage in the ship *Yeoman Bassi*.

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Sept 5 1324

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They put to sea, had fair voyage, and came in at Eyri on the selfsame day that Laurence had put out from' Gàseyri — Bertin's Day. Horses had been got for him; and Lord Bishop Laurence rode north to Hôlar, and all the folk at the seat rejoiced in him. He chanted first mass at all Holy Masses.

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“. — Now must be told how, as soon as Laurence had settled down at home at Hôlar, he shaped a fair and godly life, first, in what touched himself, and after that in all other men. And we will tell, point by point, of his conduct of life, because there is in it a pattern for many a good man who wishes to walk righteously both in spiritual and temporal things. About the way of his life we have here put together nothing that we cannot before God attest; for this man was so steadfast and settled in his conduct, that all his life he behaved himself just as thou mightest have beheld him behave any two days, night and day, if thou hadst stayed with him. In divine service he was so constant and devout that he kept every service, matins, and evensong, masses and daily hours; and no business bore so hard upon him, but he let it all go by that he might attend the holy services, winter like summer, and night like day. All the clergy who had to chant and read, deacons or clerks, he disciplined in such wise that they did it properly. Sir Olaf Hjaltason he made schoolmaster, to teach grammar. He received many scholars for teaching, rich men's sons and many poor men also, and had them taught till they were capable. All the time that he was bishop, he had a notably good school kept; brother Arni also taught many; and there were always fifteen or more going to school. Those

who had read had to repeat the lesson the evening before to the schoolmaster, and be dealt with by him if they read or chanted amiss. Sir Valthjof he made choirmaster, and his business was to settle what each should chant. Also before the highest of high-days — Yule or Easter or St. Mary's Days — he had the priests and deacons and all the clergy summoned, and then he preached and gave them a sermon on the way it behoved them to act on each high-day; admonishing them to confess above all if they had any sins in their soul unshriven. On all high feast-days he led the chanting himself, and chanted mass and preached in so scholarly and devout a fashion that many came to repent and amend because of it. Sir Valthjof stood ever by him and was his chaplain. At high mass he always had the same deacon to minister to him; this was Deacon Einar Haflidason, whom he loved beyond all his clergy, and accounted as his true and trusty friend. The service of mass itself he delivered with heartfelt piety and with tears welling; and such compunction visited the bystanders, that in the low-chant there was more weeping and catching of breath to be heard from them than clear words. All the signs of the cross he made clearly and soberly, so that it could never seem too fast or too slow, but ever in due measure. After mass, when he came into the vestry, he sometimes rebuked the deacons and clergy for aught that seemed to him to have gone carelessly in the reading or chanting or other matters. He could not bear to see a deacon with a baggy blouse under his mass-vestments and dalmatic; that, he said to them, was how the mass-vestments and the stuff got torn. Likewise no priest or deacon durst have a cope beneath his long gown, having a choir-cope outside it; he told them to tear off the gear which was tightened down round them. He would never allow singing in two or three parts, calling it fiddler's folly; no, they were to chant plain song, just as it was set in the choir-books. In the bell-ringing, he chose to have the same rule as in the days of Bishop Jorund — namely, to go out about midnight in winter. He liked those of the clergy who had to go out to have a good nap after vespers. Every time

he chanted mass, five paupers had to be taken in and given meat enough for one meal.

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45. The course of Lord Bishop Laurence' Day was this. When the bell began for matins, he read the service to the Virgin while he dressed: likewise the clergy read the service to the Virgin in the choir while the bell rang. When it pealed, the bishop came forth and was in his seat all matins chanting with the other clergy. After the chanting, he went into his quarters, and as soon as he came in he entered his study and barred himself in. No one might go in save he only; and there he stayed all alone, and in the dark moreover, about a matins' space; and he never came forth to join the rest but his cheeks were wet with tears. Then he went up into his sleeping room, and when he had gone to bed, a light was brought to him in a lantern, and for long he read the Psalter; for a very brief space drowsiness stole on him till the bell rang for primes. He read indoors as he dressed and washed. At the bell for fore-mass, he went to church and was in his place while it was chanted, and gave the blessing after mass. Then the bishop went out of and round the church. Every day on which people might be coming, he sat in his consistory to deal with cases and do other needful business, either of people that had come, or concerning the church. This went on till the bell for terces. Then the bishop straightway went out, staying at service till after mass and nones; then to table. He made all his priests sit over his table, and made them, and all that cared to come, glad with goodly cheer and liquor, either mead or small ale. Always the bishop drank a cup to each of his priests severally, when he had been let blood; and when good guests came to the house, there was a cup round for each. All double feasts were handsomely drunk; but on all high-days there was no special order, but every one drank as he would. Whether any ship was at Iceland or not, just the same cheer was to be expected at Holar. With all his guests he dealt handsomely; all of mark sat up in his room, and those that sat by him were to drink as they listed, each man no more than he pleased. Those who were more eager to drink were

none the more sought after, so that it was their own fault who were the worse for it. He made the priests always keep Yule-feast handsomely, and all the clergy, lay-prebendaries, bailiff, and housekeeper, and all the servants; so that all had cheer enough. At Easter the entertainment was moderate, likewise on high-days during Lent. Lord Laurence had such foresight that he laid in the drinkables from wherever in Iceland he could get them. He always had shares in two or three ships faring to Iceland; his managers were GrafarLeif and Eirek the 'Red.' Most commonly Holar church owned something in the ships that came to Iceland. He gave his trusty men charge over his cellar; Ketil Hallsson for the two first years of his coming to Iceland, and afterwards Deacon Einar, who kept it afterwards all the time Laurence was bishop. Daily after the meal, he first walked and then went into his study and studied books: he wrote on his waxen tablets and noted what he especially wished to take from the books, and then Deacon Einar wrote it out in a quire or book, to be at hand for the bishop when he wished to look at it and have it before him. No man might come up into his quarters without asking leave; a porter was appointed to watch the lodging by day and also by night. Whenever it began to get dark in the winter, Deacon Einar would tell to the bishop in Norse lives of the saints, or would sometimes read Latin stories till the vesper bell; at the first ringing the bishop would go straight out to church, reading requiems with the clergy as he went. After evensong the bishop went home to his quarters and then to table. He always made some cleric read a lesson before his table; most commonly Ôblaud Thorsteinsson, deacon, did so. In the evening, after the meal, the bishop walked about the floor at bathing-time, and then went to his bed and had his longest sleep straight on till matins. Lord Laurence never came into the monastery, save sometimes when he was told that dancing was going on in the evenings. Then he had a lantern borne before him into the great room, forbidding each and all to have dancing there in the monastery. Much zeal showed Lord Laurence about the conduct of the clerks, the cut of their hair and dress; and

against their making any show there in his diocese; also about their way of life, especially where he thought there was excess; also about those people who, either by way of adultery or incest, lived together forbiddenly.

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46. It is not to be forgotten, but rather to be made known to righteous men, how many and how goodly charities he had endowed from the goods of the church at Hôlar while he was bishop. All the provost's revenue that came in by fines or other penalties, he gave to the poor who needed it sorest, most of all to those who had before had a household; to lepers, blind folk, or those who had the worst sickness. For this he appointed a priest to exact the provost's revenue; Sir Paul Thorsteinsson had the place first, and then Sir Bjorn Ôfeigsson. To these the bishop gave for their trouble such a share of the income as he thought good; and so it stood during his life. This was a mighty help to many poor people, and every one paid in with goodwill. Twelve almsmen he established there at Hôlar and in the storehouses of the church; these were both fed and clad.

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Sept 29

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In Lent five paupers were taken in and stayed on till over Easter-week. On Michaelmas Day in autumn, the steward had to measure off two thousand four hundred in wadmal, and this had to be given to the poor for keeping through the winter, and till after Whitsun-week. This the guest-man had to give out and distribute among the paupers whom he thought neediest — or else the bishop directed him — before the highest days. A trusty, benevolent, shrewd man, Thorstein Thorleifsson, was chosen for this. All the goods given yearly in wadmal to the church he had taken home to his quarters, and given to the poor. — Also be it noted, that Laurence had the same apparel as monks wear, a cowl and a long gown outermost; for he declared the rule to be, that though bishops were of the black monks' order, they were bound

to have the same dress as that of the rule they were chosen to. A shirt of hair and wool he wore next him. He set up a school in the monastery, and had Latin taught. Sir Ôlaf Hjaltason then kept the school, and Laurence gave him the living of Vellir church in Svarfadar-dale, saying that whoever was schoolmaster at Hôlar should always have that living. Sir Valthjôf taught chanting.

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47. During Laurence's first winter at Hôlar, there was little tidings all over Iceland.

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1324-25

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Brother Berg Sokkason was chosen by Lord Laurence to be abbot at Mûnka-Thverâ, and consecrated by him at home at Hôlar a year later. He was a man of parts beyond most people then in Iceland, in scholarship, handwriting, chanting, and eloquence; and he drew up many histories of the Saints in Norse, which shall be known and famous while this country is peopled. Moreover this good man lived nobly in monastic discipline. Abbot Berg and Bishop Laurence were the dearest of friends, Laurence being Berg's teacher. In the winter before Lent, Lord Laurence sent his son, brother Arni, south to Skâlholt to Lord Bishop John, begging him to ordain him to all orders up to that of priest. Brother Ami came north after Whitsun week, now ordained priest. It seemed to Lord Bishop Laurence a finer thing for a father not to lay hands of consecration upon his son after the flesh: nor did brother Arni ever stand by his father, save when he was confirming G the young. Brother Ârni was an excellent scholar and versifier, and taught many clerks: he always went with Lord Laurence his father on his visitations, and slept in the same quarters. Also he, and likewise Deacon Einar, had the bishop's signet and the writing of his letters.

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48. That same winter, in the autumn before which Bishop Laurence came out, there was a lull in Iceland and no event of note. The aforesaid bishops were in power, Lord John at Skálholt, and Lord Laurence at Holar. People said that there could never have been better Latin scholars in Iceland than they; also between them at this time was the greatest affection. In the second year of Laurence's bishopric, he, with the counsel of all the learned in Holar see, enacted that the feast of Corpus Christi should be kept with the festal chanting of a high-day; for this had just been proclaimed by Bishop John. This high-day was made law at the General Moot in summer. In autumn afterwards Lord Laurence performed ordinations at home at Holar. It was another of the notable things about his rule, that he examined the clergy himself, and himself told them to their faces how it beseeemed them to behave in the ordination they were receiving; and most piercingly he overhauled their life and their knowledge before he would go on to consecrate them; he laid most upon the way they chanted or read in Holy Church. Then he said that [those should not] receive holy orders, who expected to have a child and would not declare it; and when this was discovered he laid heavy penances on them, and made them forfeit his ministrations for a long time.

287

In the year after Lord Laurence' coming, no ship came to Iceland. In the spring afterwards Abbot Gudmund and Yeoman Benedict Kolbeinsson rode to Hôlar. Abbot Gudmund inquired how he would settle about the tithes; a matter that had long been stirring between Thingeyri and the church of Hôlar. Thus said Lord Bishop Laurence to Abbot Gudmund:

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'There are two ways; one to complain about the tithes before my Lord archbishop; the other, to submit this whole case into our hands to be set straight.' And with good men's counsel the abbot elected that the bishop alone should fix and fashion the affair as he would, having sworn before God that Thingeyri monastery should not be the loser.

Then the bishop pronounced that he made over Hvamm in Vatn-dale to the monastery at Thingeyri for a perpetual possession.

289

‘We know well,’ said Bishop Laurence, ‘that every single bishop of Hôlar has so much power and authority over Thingeyri monastery, that the abbots of Thingeyri never lay claim to the tithes of the bishops of Hôlar west of Vatn-dale river. But, to the end that our successors may claim no authority over the monastery at Thingeyri, we desire with this gift and bounty to abate all ‘wrangling and complaint while we have any choice in the matter. Also we will write to the archbishop asking him to confirm this our covenant.’ This agreement was sealed by deeds and hand-pledges. Then Lord Laurence also gave to Thingeyri his brother Kâlf’s donation; it was four thousand eight hundred worth, and by this gift Lord Bishop Laurence had honour and glory, but the monastery at Thingeyri eternal gain and emolument while Hvamm lasts.

290

49. Thorstein Kolbeinsson, the brother of Benedict, was now dwelling at Holtastad in Langadale. The Lady Gudrûn, daughter of Thorstein, was mother of the two brothers. Thorstein was then unwed, but was keeping a lawless union, for he took Gudrun, Illugi’s daughter, to live with him. Thorstein and Thord Loptsson were fourth cousins. This living together became known, for she became with child. So openly did they go about their union that he took her to his own bed as if she were his lawful wife. Lord Laurence at first admonished him kindly to part with her. But he was hardened in his perverseness and paid no heed to the bishop’s admonitions. At last Bishop Laurence proceeded with legal evidence against Thorstein, getting sworn proof of the kinship between the said Thorstein and Thord, who was the husband of Gudrun before this. Thereafter the bishop gave Thorstein three admonitions, summoning him to Holar; the last was summary, and said that if he did not come to the said church, Laurence would excommunicate them on the First Lady-Day there at Hôlar, with

candles reversed and bell-ringing. And inasmuch as they came not to the summons, but hardened their hearts, behaving as before, the next thing was that the bishop excommunicated them on Lady-day in the chancel at Holar, with the form which Holy Church enjoins should be chiefly used against refractoriness. Herein was manifested the singlemindedness and righteousness of the bishop; for the Lady Gudrun and Benedict were his dearest friends, and also Hallbera, the abbess at Stad, the Lady Gudrun's sister. Thorstein also had a large following, being a man very rich in substance. Now it must be told how Thorstein took this procedure and this ban which was going forward at Holar on Lady-day. When he had come to table at Holtstad, he hid his face in his palms, and then looking up said:

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'Gudrun, methinks I feel that now the bishop at Holar is chanting a stern song over you and me this day: I will not tangle other folk in my own troubles, and all of you,' this he said speaking to the people, 'must eat in here, and I will go hence.' Then he left the table, ate alone, and slept alone. Before this the bishop had sent away the two priests, for he had dealt ruthlessly with them. For soon after these doings the Lady Gudrun and Benedict rode to Holtstad, and urged Thorstein to be reconciled with Holy Church and the bishop. The pair met the bishop at Vellir in Svarfadardale, and the bishop took the ban off Thorstein; and off Gudrún in Arshaw some days after. They both swore to part, and with God's will part they did. The bishop took every pains to chastise those under him out of evil ways: but he never banned any other men openly in Holar see.

292

50. Especially is it to be named and noted, how Lord Laurence was always saying at the synod of priests, that it went past bounds that those priests, who chanced to be disabled by age or other ailments, should be driven to tramp and beg; the church and her goods helping them hardly at all. Accordingly he founded and ordered an infirmary for priests at Kviâ-Beck in Ôlafs-Firth, and bought half of the ground

from priest Arnod, the church owning the other half. There he laid out a great fund in estate and live stock and farm gear, and also enacted that every priest in the see should contribute half a mark a year for the next three years: this swelled to a great fund.. Also over all Ôlafs-Firth and all Fljot he had a lamb kept in each" house, so that soon as many as fifty were reared, and people ever after yielded them up to the bishop for his estates. None the less did Lord Laurence reserve for the infirmary the fines for misconduct which came in in great suits; as for instance from Benedict Kolbeinsson and Thorstein his brother and other men of means who were liable for heavy penances. He chose Kvia-Beck in Ôlafs-Firth for the infirmary, because he thought it was a good place for cod-fish and meat, well fitted for old men's diet. There he made oversee a young priest who had been his pupil of old when he was in Munka-Thvera, saying he thought he would have ripe judgment in managing the stock. This was Bjôrn Ônundarson, priest, and he stayed steward here while Bishop Laurence lived; and into his hand came good store of all manner of live stock and provisions, so that there was no lack there till Bishop Laurence departed; many priests were then there. This same Bjorn was long steward at Modruvellir in the Valley of the Horg, and was a man of ripe counsel, the words being fulfilled which Laurence foretold of him.

293

Sir Snjolf landed in the south and rode up to Holar, having got a letter from some of the canons who entreated Bishop Laurence to make good terms with him. He would not do a reverence to Bishop Laurence, and the bishop replied to his speech not a word. Then he went to seek Bishop John at Skâlholt, and offered to minister in his see. John counselled Snjolf to go back to Bishop Laurence.

294

'You are bound,' said Bishop John, 'to humble yourself before him, seeing he is appointed by God your superior. If you will promise us this, we will even write north unto our brother.' Snjolf went north to

Laurence and made him a reverence, falling on his knees. The bishop asked —

295

‘Why so little like thyself, compared with what thou wert when here last, Snjölf?’

296

‘Because,’ he said, ‘now is my neck quit of the iron prong; also Bishop John enjoined upon me that I should yield unto you.’ Then the bishop rose up and set him beside him, and for that day entertained him, and there was such concord between them, that he gave him the benefice of Håls in Fnjôska-dale, none other being then empty. He could say with truth of Sir Snjölf, that no man dressed or feasted so finely as he; yet never did he assess himself for tithe at more than forty-eight hundred. There was ever a sharpness between them; but it was Snjölf who attacked the bishop with vainglorious words, Once at Munka-Thvera, when the bishop had come there on a visitation, this happened. When the bishop was at meat Sir Snjölf came in and found a place set for him at a table by the door. Then, as Snjölf got tipsy, there came on him a spirit of cursings and revilings against the bishop. Very long-suffering was Bishop Laurence, answering not a word, and only breaking up the feast after Our Lady had been pledged. That night Snjölf took quite enough to drink, and swelled so big as to be on the brink of peril. Then he was belted about with a linen kerchief, and his writhings seemed to the bystanders piteous to look on. Then he begged for Lord Bishop Laurence to come to him; which he did. Then Sir Snjölf prayed forgiveness for the words he had said in the evening. The bishop said he would give it blithely, and then read over him. And, by God’s will, a little after, he mended. Sir Snjölf never again reviled Bishop Laurence in his life.

297

Lord Laurence bore great friendship to Sir John Kodransson, and gave him a share in the benefice at Glen Hrafna, and therewith a provostship over Eyja Firth and Dal, as far as the Rift of Vard. He was a

most goodly scholar, and had the church at Glen Hrafna mended at such cost, that it would have been long there manifest, had it only been kept up.

298

51. All the foremost men in Iceland, lay or learned, bore affection to Laurence while he was there. They could borrow from the church on condition that they left gold or refined silver in pawn; and that, if repayment was not forthcoming, the church kept the deposit. Thus the bishop got much treasure by their not redeeming their pledges. The bishop and Sküli Flugumyri lent money to Lord Eirek Sveinbjarnason for four years, he having then the bailiwick over the Northern Quarter. He borrowed over fourteen hundred and forty a year, paying up some in house repairs, more as the church and bishop needed. With rich men the bishop took pains about fixing the tithe, especially with Gizur 'Gall,' yeoman at the Tongue of Vidi-dale; naming three priests and three laymen to value his goods while he was entertaining the bishop. At first Gizur was stubborn against it; but when he saw that a ban hung over him unless the bishop had his way — for the bishop desired him to name three laymen as valuers — it was all settled, and they valued the goods at seven thousand two hundred more than Gizur had before paid tithe on. Not many people had trouble with Gizur after that. Lord Laurence had no respect of persons in chastising, and found fault with aught which he saw was against God's laws, whether they who did it were rich or poor. It was also notable how, when Benedict or yeoman Rafn or other men of mark were taken in adultery, they had to come to Holar on Maunday Thursday and be brought up, just like other penitents, in a bearskin; likewise sometimes, on Ash Wednesday they who had more grievously backslidden. But he bade them sit by him at banquet through Easter, and made them welcome. He so managed because he thought that it would bring them to the blush to receive such disgrace publicly for their misdoing, and that they would beware of backsliding again; for they would rather pay a trifle than abase themselves like so many nobodies.

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1327

300

52. In the third year of Lord Laurence's episcopate, brother ïngimund Skütuson came from Norway with writs of Lord Archbishop Eilif concerning the case of Modruvellir; the tenor of his decree was, that Lord John Bishop of Skálholt and Lord Thorlak, abbot at Ver, were appointed by the archbishop judges delegate with power to take evidence, 'and with authority so to decide or quash, that a covenant should be come to in the said suit: also to summon on either side, to wit, on behalf of Laurence Bishop of Hôlar Church, and for the accusation on behalf of the brethren of the aforesaid cloister.' And when this decree reached the aforesaid judges, they issued summonses on both sides, namely to Bishop Laurence and the brethren of the said cloister for the day after the first day of St. Ôlaf, at Modruvellir.

301

And when all were there assembled, the July 30 brethren, namely brother Thorgeir, brother Thôrd, and brother ïngimund, all of that order, lodged their complaint against Bishop Laurence. First then they claimed their monastery, to which they were consecrated; next, that the bishops of Hôlar, namely Audun, and now Laurence, had taken all the income of the monastery for the church at Hôlar ever since the monastery was burnt; and they had had to provide for themselves like so many laymen. And for the said reasons they craved the judges to deal them justice.

302

To these things Bishop Laurence made answer, 'All men know that the monastery here at Modruvellir stood before the fire and before I was chosen bishop. Also the brethren were appointed priestly maintenance. This suit was also pleaded, and this charge brought by brother ïngimund before the archbishop in Norway when we were last there. We, not having acted, have not to answer for our own person. Thus we begin our answer; — in all things are we willing to answer to

and obey the archbishop; let his ordinance stand. Our offer is to have the monastery here at Modruvellir put in repair, with all speed and the best means we can find; likewise that as many brethren be received in as were there when Bishop Jorund departed, with maintenance found in clothing and victual, even as they had in Bishop Jorund's days. We will appoint a prior over the order, and be ourselves their abbot, and set a steward over the foundation and its funds. In grave matters all is to be done with the counsel of the prior and brethren. This monastery is to be in all matters spiritual and secular according as it was founded by Bishop Jorund of excellent memory.' At these words of Bishop Laurence there was a loud cheer.

303

Then spoke first Bishop John: 'Brethren, ye have now heard the lord bishop's offer; it is now for yourselves to choose; will ye follow up the accusation that is begun, or will ye make a covenant according to his offer?' The brethren said they would take the way he should counsel them.

304

John answered, 'We would call some more men of weight to help us.' Then Lord Laurence and his following departed. He had ere that called all the chief scholars in Holar See, and laymen likewise. After a while Bishop Laurence with his following was called, in, and Bishop John spoke then on the brethren's behalf:

305

'Whereas, lord bishop, you have made offer to the brethren, utterly without compulsion or bond of law; they desire to choose that you have the monastery repaired with all speed and at fitting charges, as you have abundant means, with furniture and bells found, and all things needful to the ministry and service of Holy Church; that a prior and warden be appointed over the monastery, clothed and fed in a seemly style; and that the monastery and brethren be in all ways established as in the days of Bishop Jorund when he first founded it; and we twain here, judges-delegate appointed by our lord archbishop,

consent, confirm, and assure this with our seals.' This covenant was agreed to, all those aforesaid consenting with goodwill and affection, without any compulsion or force. This agreement was made by Bishop John joining their hands, and was ratified after by the hand and seal of either party. The most noble feast was given at Modruvellir to both the bishops, to Abbot Thorlâk, and to all priests and laymen that came. Thence they all rode off together, bishops and all aforesaid; for Lord Laurence invited them all home to Hôlar to feast; Bishop John, Abbot Thorlâk, and, all their following. This was on the first day of St. Ôlaf. Lord Laurence gave the goodliest gifts to Bishop John and also to Abbot Thorlâk, and they parted the best of friends for the nonce. Thence they rode to Glaumbaer, and yeoman Rafn gave great gifts to John the bishop. After that John rode to Thingeyri, being close friends with Abbot Gudmund, and there also was loaded with goodly gifts. He was at Breidabôlstad on the feast of St. Laurence, chanted mass and preached there; and Sir Thorstein gave him goodly gifts. Thus he rode west into his diocese, and this ride of Bishop John's north got him great friends.

306

53. Now it must be told how Bishop Laurence got together carpenters, and had the convent at Modruvellir done up, providing furniture and bells. 'Apostles' bells and also five 'singing-maids' were brought north from Hôlar; and soon this was finished in so good a style, that it is visible unto this day.

307

1328

308

Thus all went on in peace and quietness over the summer and right on until the next Lent.

309

Brother ïngimund, in Lent, rode south to Skalholt, no man at first knowing his business. Brother Thorgeir was appointed prior at Modruvellir, and Thorkel Grimsson warden. Hard on Passion Week

came a messenger from Bishop John with letters — close, short, and sharp. After greeting, it ran thus:

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‘Brother ĩngimund from Modruvellir swooped down on us unawares, like a thunderclap, ere we knew it. He brought tidings, Lord Bishop Laurence, that you had not kept the covenant which we struck in summer at Modruvellir; wherefore we see nought else fitting for us but to ride north in the summer and decide the said suit once for all.’

311

Upon this letter Bishop Laurence was vexed and wroth, saying to the man he trusted, that he had hoped better things of Bishop John when they parted last at Hólar than that he would so quickly reverse his love towards him, and trust, without the least evidence, the tales of his foes, that he was breaking the covenant which he and the brethren had made between them, and which, he said, he desired to keep to the last tittle. Further, that the authority of Bishop John and Abbot Thorlák over his covenant with the brethren to decide over the said case, was dead and done with; and he showed thereon the canon law. And summoning his chief priests he showed them the canon law upon it. In spring after Easter, on the day of John Bishop of Holar, he sent Sir Paul Thorsteinsson to Skálholt with letters. He had composed a long letter wherein he set forth certain legal points; namely, Abbot Thorlák and the Bishop had no more authority in the said case to decide, because of the covenant which he had made with the brethren. This letter of Bishop Laurence Sir Paul took to Bishop John, who, as soon as he had read it, was much vexed, saying that for all this letter he would proceed just as before. Then he asked Sir Paul, would he have to write over again what he had writ before, namely, that he would still ride north in summer to decide on the Modruvellir case? But Sir Paul said he cared not to go back with that letter. Then, said the Bishop, he would not write another. Sir Paul went back to Holar and told Bishop Laurence that it stood thus. So time went on till after Whitsun-week.

312

54. On Trinity Sunday two deacons and a man with them came from Skálholt to Holar. One was deacon Thôrd? son of Lawman Gudmund, whom Laurence had taken quite a child at Thingeyri, and taught and spent all his pains on teaching him, so that he was the best Latin scholar and a good versifier; ill it beseeemed him to go with any errand contrary to the ordinance given him by Bishop Laurence. The other deacon was called Gregory. These deacons went into the vestry when the bishop was disrobed. Thord greeted the bishop, saying that he had a letter and ordinance of Bishop John to read before him. The bishop answered, that he probably had an ordinance which would be little good to Holy Church or to himself: 'Thord, thou needst not set thyself to read any letters of summons here before me in the church, for I will hear none such.' And when Thord was purposing to read out the letter, the bishop sprang up and left the vestry and all the clergy with him.

313

And when Thord saw this, he said: 'This serves me not; I now see that the bishop will not hear the ordinance of Bishop John.' Bishop Laurence said he would not raise the authority of Bishop John and Thorlæk from the dead by listening to any summons of theirs. Then the bishop went to table and asked the deacons to eat with him; they stayed Sunday, and were well feasted with meat and drink. On the morrow after primes, they went to table and gave out that they meant to ride away speedily, and took their horses and saddled them; and as soon as high mass was sung, after offertory at mass, Deacon Thord went before the Virgin's altar and began the letter, Bishop Laurence sitting in his seat. And when Bishop Laurence heard Thord begin the letter, he said: —

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'Thord! I forbid thee to read any letter or to make stir or brawling during divine service of mass.' At that instant Sir Valthjof leapt from his seat and gripped the letter with both hands, thinking to tear it from him. And when the bishop saw it, he called to him —

315

‘Take not the letter from him, but put them, letter and all, out of the church, so that they brawl not in holy mass.’ Then the clergy flew at them from all sides, and elbowed them out of church, and locked the door behind them. Then Thord set to reading out the letter in the tower without the church, and afterwards nailed it up on the church door with iron nails. Then they jumped on their horses which they had tied outside the churchyard, and halted not till they reached Skálholt, and told Bishop John how it had fared with their journey, and spared no word of the tale how they had been haled perforce out of church, but hid utterly how the bishop had made them welcome. Little pleased was Bishop John; but priests and learned men saw the letter fixed on the church door at Holar and read it. This letter was in Latin, a fine composition, and showing the surpassing scholarship of Bishop John. The tenor of the said letter was, that Lord John and Thorlâk, being judges by Archbishop Eilff appointed, summoned Bishop Laurence to Modruvellir, in the Hôrg Valley, on the plaint of the brethren to hear their judgment between the church of Hôlar and the convent of Môdruvellir. The day of summons was the morrow of the translation of St. Benedict.

316

55. Now to tell how Lord John and Abbot Thorlâk made ready to journey north over the land. With them travelled Lord Ketil and many great men both lay and learned; and they reached Môdruvellir ere the summoning day, bringing their own victual and drink; yet Lord Laurence had arranged a handsome entertainment for them. Bishop Laurence summoned to his side the chief priests, Sir Thorstein ‘Shardstone,’ Sir Egil, Sir John, Sir Eirfk ‘Bowl.’ He had meant to visit over the northern quarter, but stayed in Lauf Ridge as the day of meeting drew near. There he treated and took counsel with his priests about what was best to do. All agreed that he ought to go to Modruvellir on the day of summons; as it seemed likely that the judges would proceed each to his decision, which would damage the church at Holar in default of any man to speak for it; and it seemed also likely

that they would say he was disloyal to the archbishop, and either interdict him or summon him before the archbishop. He showed them the canon law, declaring that the people had no authority to give judgment after the covenant was once made between him and the brethren; and said that he had in no wise broken that. The end was that Bishop Laurence went by his priests' counsel, and accompanied them by ship over to Modruvellir.

317

Laurence and the bishop met in the church, and Lord Laurence was moving forward to kiss him; but he drew back, saying: 'Is it true that you have bidden them lay hands on my deacons in the church at Holar and thrust them out?'

318

'I do not own that I bade lay hands on them; but this I own, that I forbade them to brawl in holy church; also it was not to my liking to hear your letter.'

319

'It is told me,' said Bishop John, 'that two men did lay hands on them, and they were your priest Valthjof and your scribe called Sigurd 'Pruning-knife'; them I hold excommunicate, and I will have no commerce with them till they are cleared; but whereas you do not own that you commanded it, I will not go so far against you.'

320

Then many good men tried their best to make a compromise between them. In the evening, Bishop John chose to sit at meat by his own people, Laurence sitting in another room with his. Next morning both bishops went into the bishop's study, and all the chief men were summoned thither. The men from the south had a great load of canon law-books which had been brought north. Bishop John opened his speech in Latin, saying to all that understood what had passed in the Môdruvellir case, and bidding Lord Laurence answer.

321

Lord Laurence spoke in Norse. ‘We all know, Lord John, that you have as fine a flow of Latin as of your mother-tongue. But it is not understood of the people. Therefore, let us talk clearly so that all may understand. Thus, then, clearly say I; that I will keep and abide by the covenant made last summer. Let it be proved in any jot, that I or my steward have started from it, and then I will amend joyfully.’ At this speech of his there was a loud cheer.

322

Bishop John answered: ‘That deed which was drawn last summer we call a deed of your sharp practice, and we think that it cannot stand; for the rules of St. Augustine fix, that an abbot or prior who is put in command of the monastery shall have authority both in secular and spiritual things; and therefore we, judges in this case set and appointed, hold to the prescription of the rules, that the brethren here at Môdruvellir should have authority in secular things even as within their walls they have in spiritual. And so it stands far and wide in monasteries over all the world; for it beseems not that the brethren be the almsmen of laymen serving God as they do night and day. We twain with God’s will shall be disposed to give judgment and decision thereon, if the brethren are not to get hold of the rents and maintenance which the rules ordain; superiors being merely appointed to have power of control over the goods which belong to the church. Now, if a prior is appointed here at Môdruvellir over the brethren, and is to have no power over their goods of this world; suppose that the brethren were to ask him for necessary vesture or victuals, he refers them to the bishop at Hôlar, their abbot, and the bishop refers to his steward. But it is a long day’s journey between the bishop’s seat at Hôlar and the monastery at Môdruvellir, and the brethren cannot suffer lack for ever. Secondly, the prior has to require zeal in discipline. Some brethren being obedient, some disobedient, it is for the prior to comfort the obedient with every indulgence that it is fitting should comfort their hearts, and to better their discipline. But now he has nothing to do with it; the bishop’s steward at Holar rules all the funds,

and will not yield whatever the prior settles. Do not then the obedient brethren lose their comforts? and like enough they may fly into league with the malcontents. We twain, judges by the archbishop appointed, will never consent to the prior and brethren not having full power over secular things, even as Bishop Jorund has ordained. And though in his main plan of the monastery his scheme has been goodly, yet it is fitting enough to mend any flaw there may be in his handiwork.' Lord Bishop John spoke so finely with all his eloquence that to many there it looked like the law that the prior and brethren should have full power in secular things.

323

56. Bishop Laurence said he would stand by the covenant which the brethren and he had made in the summer before; and the longer the bishops parleyed, the stiffer grew Lord Bishop John. Bishop Laurence begged leave from the meeting to confer with his priests; and when this was got from Bishop John, Lord Laurence asked the priests and other trusty men of his, what was the wisest way to take in the said case. But they all threw it back upon Laurence himself; some however gave ill counsel; but he felt himself the spirit in which it was tendered.

324

Then said Bishop Laurence: 'I see how this case will go; if Bishop John and Abbot Thorlák persist in their decision, adjudging all authority to the brethren over secular matters at Modruvellir, it seems to us somewhat doubtful that the archbishop would reverse that decision. But even though, for peace and quietness, it is our doing that the brethren have temporal control over their funds, it seems to us more likely that the archbishop would annul that disposition of ours, if he thought it unbefitting, and then there would be some hope of his choosing the covenant to be kept to which we made last summer.' So this point of his plan was decided, namely, to obstruct the decision, and risk it. Then he sent on to them two of his priests, who came back with the message that on this occasion they must go themselves. Bishop Laurence went into the room, and then the brethren were summoned.

Bishop John asked Laurence to what agreement he would come with the brethren.

325

‘I will choose — what many will put down as puny in me — to agree that the brethren at Môdruvellir shall have authority in temporal things, rather than that we wrangle; provided the archbishop lets this settlement stand.’

326

The brethren agreed to keep this covenant; it was ratified with hand-pledging that the Lord prior should have all authority over the foundation and all the property, whether land or chattels, without the walls even as within. Thorgeir was made prior, and Bishop Laurence had all the property in land and chattels made over to him, and the funds were written off the funds of Holar church. And when this was done, Lord John, Abbot Thorlâk, Lord Ketil and all the Southrons, rode south on the fell. It was in all the people’s mouth that Bishop Laurence had let himself sing quite small to the Southrons. The bishops parted cordially, as it was right they should in public; yet not with such hearty affection as in the summer before. Bishop Laurence visited over the northern district till Lady-day. There were then two ships to Gâseyri bound to Norway that summer.

327

57. Now to tell how Bishop Laurence called to him Sir Egil of Grenjadarstad, and among other things spoke thus in his ear:— ‘Everybody knows how ill the Modruvellir suit turned out last summer; I had to yield before the great power against me, though I thought I was right in my case. But I like it ill, that the case should remain like this — namely, the brethren at Modruvellir having to rule the whole property. They will squander ignorantly and foolishly all the funds which Bishop Jorund gave away from those of Holar church, and into the clutches of fools; while the agreement made last summer is made void and a dead letter now, Sir Egil, my disciple, seeing that thou art best and foremost trusted to do my will, I have thought of a journey to

Norway in summer for thee, with letters from me to the archbishop on business, touching the Modruvellir case.'

328

Sir Egil answered: 'I feel that I have received much good of you, and that I should be most bounden to do your will towards all men. Yet I know that I have myself neither scholarship, knowledge, nor eloquence enough to go forward with this business; this above all, because such mighty men have been there to preside over this case; and also because you have now consented and ratified with your own seal that the brethren should themselves have the secular power. I perceive it will prove a hard matter to take that deed back.'

329

'Thou knowest,' said Bishop Laurence, 'that I did that for peace and quietness; consented, I mean, to the second settlement; for I saw that the church of Hôlar would take harm irreparable, if Bishop John and Thorlâk had adjudged the management of the funds to the brothers, and much property to boot.'

330

At last, Bishop Laurence begging and bidding him to go, he said: '*Mighty is the master's word*; I will do as you will.'

331

At this the bishop rejoiced greatly, and straightway passage for Sir Egil and his page was taken at Gaseyri. Lord Laurence sent the archbishop goodly gifts, and the whole case written out, and both the covenants, by Egil's hand. He wrote a schedule which he had compiled from the canon law; showing how after the first covenant was made, the power of the deputy judges was over, and they had no more to do with the case. And when the ship was ready to go, Sir Egil took leave of Laurence. They soon had a fair wind and a good voyage after they put to sea, and reached Norway near Throndhjem. Sir Egil went with all speed to meet the archbishop, and made over to him the letter, the announcement, and the gifts of Bishop Laurence. All this the

archbishop took in good part, asking him to winter there with one lad in his manor and at his charges.

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Sir Egil accepted, and sat through the winter on a steward's chair, in high favour.

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58. On the other hand it is to be told how Lord John heard that Bishop Laurence was sending Sir Egil on a voyage; and it seemed likely to him that he was going about the Môdruvellir case. So he sent the priest whom he deemed foremost in his see, Sir Amgrim Brandsson, who had the benefice of Oddastad. Bishop John and Abbot Thorlak wrote about Môdruvellir, giving account of the last covenant made between Bishop Laurence and the brethren, and praying the archbishop to stablish and ratify that settlement. Sir Arngrim took ship, had a good voyage, reached Norway, went with all speed to the archbishop's presence, and gave him the letters of Bishop John and Abbot Thorlak. The archbishop took it well, asked Sir Amgrim up to his manor with one lad, to have his keep there through the winter, and made him sit on the steward's bench. The steward gave both messengers one loft to sleep in, and they loved one another like two brothers after the flesh. During the winter their behaviour was different. Sir Egil got into the archbishop's good graces as often as he could, pleading his case and the arguments of which Laurence had already given him notes. The archbishop soon perceived that Sir Egil was a great scholar and lawyer, and Sir Egil was always in the archbishop's study at his ear, pleading about the Modruvellir case, and showing to him how well the covenant which they had made, Bishop Laurence on one side, and the brethren of Modruvellir on the other, had been kept in every tittle; how he had had their monastery mended, and a church put up, with bells and furniture, and proper maintenance all found. All this Sir Egil showed to the archbishop under the hand and seal of excellent priests

and likewise of laymen; and the end soon was that the archbishop believed his pleading utterly. But Sir Arngrim spent his days otherwise, going daily to an organmaster then in Throndhjem, and he had so many lessons on the organ that he never pleaded about the Modruvellir case before the archbishop. The messengers had the best of entertainment from the archbishop through the winter.

335

59. Now to tell of what went on in Iceland after they had gone to Norway. When the brethren at Modruvellir took control over the funds, all went improvidently. Uppsala-Hrolf, and many yeomen over the Horg Valley and Eyja Firth were mixed up with Prior Thorgeir; and it was costly, because they and their followers were often entertained at Modruvellir. But the brethren supposed that they did not receive from Bishop Laurence the funds which — so they thought — belonged of old to Modruvellir. The bishop said, that they had enough to take care of, and that they were mismanaging the funds which he had made over to them. The bishop was in high displeasure that laymen were mixed up with them. In the winter after Yule Prior Thorgeir rode away from Modruvellir, meaning to go south to Skálholt. He lodged at Reykir in Skaga Firth, where Sir Thorleif then dwelt, the best harp-player in Iceland. During the night he stayed there, it came to pass that all the letters which he had in his keeping, and which had been stored in the same building as their saddles, were stolen from him. Many yeomen from Eyja Firth and the Horg Valley had sent letters by the prior south to Bishop John of Skálholt. It was laid to the charge of Sir Björn Ôfeigsson, who had then the provostship over Skaga Firth, that he had sent thither the gallants of his following to get at the letters, and that he had taken them to the bishop: but this talk was never proved. Prior Thorgeir went south to Skálholt, and there met Lord Bishop John at home, who welcomed him heartily, and there some nights he stayed. At last, before Prior Thorgeir took his leave, Lord John the bishop had a very splendid gilt chalice brought out, and also a pair of copes; he said: ‘These treasures we wish to give to the church at

Modruvellir and to St. Augustine's monastery, for an everlasting possession, for atonement of our sins and for our soul's health; we would fain do this so that no man may truly say that we have in any wise despoiled the monastery, or taken any bribe to back up the brethren in their suit against Bishop Laurence; nay, we see nought surer in the sight of God, than that the brethren should have full power over their goods, without as within the walls, any man notwithstanding.'

336

Prior and bishop parted right cordially. The things which Bishop John gave to the church at Modruvellir are to be seen within it. The prior returned from his ride south; and Bishop Laurence was displeased that he had gone into another See and not first asked his leave. Uppsala-Hrolf and his following, yeomen from Eyja Firth and the Horg Valley, were offended with Bishop Laurence, because the letters which they had sent with Prior Thorgeir to Bishop John had been stolen, and they laid it to Laurence' charge. But this could not be said with any truth; for he never knew of the prior's ride south till Sir Bjorn told him of it.

337

60. In the spring after Easter, Bishop Laurence called his friends to him, both priests and laymen, and made known to them that he wished to ride North to Modruvellir, and see how the brethren there were behaving in their, walk; for news had come that there was lack at Modruvellir of meat and hay. Bishop Laurence rode North on Heljar-dale heath, and reached Modruvellir on the day which he had named before in his letter. As many as forty men were there, Uppsala-Hrolf and yeomen from the Vale of Horg and Eyja Firth. No procession was made to meet the bishop, but there stood the aforesaid yeomen armed. First the bishop and his people went to the church; there was no sort of greeting for them from the brethren. At meal-time the bishop sat in the great room; it was so disposed that the yeomen sat on one dais, and the bishop and his people on another; and the yeomen had from the brethren far better cheer than the bishop and his people. There the

bishop stayed one night; not speaking to the brethren, nor they to him. Thence Bishop Laurence rode to Munka-Thverâ, and stayed two nights there; there was the finest feast made for him by Abbot Berg. It was said when he rode from Modruvellir, that he would ride back westwards on Ôxna-dale's Heath, and not go to Modruvellir. But the bishop would not change his course like this. From Munka-Thverâ he rode back to Modruvellir. The brethren had sent away the crowd; and Benedict Kolbeinsson and his lads were with the bishop. In the evening meat was given to the bishop and his folk. On the morrow Laurence went to the chapter and brethren, and asked the prior to show him the stores and hay and sheep. The prior and brethren said they would show him neither stores nor hay nor anything else. The bishop asked for the keys, but could not get them. The bishop said that he would not be answerable before God for their waste of the church funds, but that the church at Hôlar was bound to make restitution of any shortness in the funds. Then the bishop made his clergy take the keys from them by force, and had an inspection forthwith of the stores; and it was seen that there was no provisions either of meat or hay. He set a steward to manage the stores, and even appointed a prior also, Steindôr the brother of Abbot Berg. Prior Thorgeir he took along with him perforce, and got the whole management of the monastery in his hands before he went home to Holar. Many said what sharp practice it seemed in Bishop Laurence to take into his hand the whole temporal administration of the brethren, before any news came of the way the archbishop chose to settle it, or whether he leaned more to the mission of Sir Egil or to that of Sir Arngrim on Bishop John's behalf. Bishop Laurence said he knew full well that the archbishop's will would be to let the covenant stand which was made in the summer before; this he said he knew by his dreams, and likewise by his heart's boding. The word goes—' *Sooth for the soothsayer*,' and so it was here. Many said that he seemed very bold, while it was doubtful how the archbishop would award on the case.

61. Now to tell what passed in Norway, the bishop's messengers being in the archbishop's manor through the next winter. Sir Egil pled his bishop's — Lord Bishop Laurence' — message whenever he could before the archbishop; but Sir Arngrim gave more heed to picking up organplaying, and did not think to plead before the archbishop about the course of the Môdruvellir case. In spring, after Easter, Sir Egil came before the archbishop and said that time was flying, that he had a long journey before him, first south to Bergen and thence to Iceland; there being no passage to Iceland then from Throndhjem. The archbishop took it well, and said that he should get done whatever business he wished. He had the canon summoned, who was most skilled in writing letters in Latin, and told him what the business was to be. 'Sir Egil shall stay with you and tell you the whole case to the bottom.' The master did the archbishop's bidding, and next day the canon showed to the archbishop the writ, which was written in lordly Latin. Thereupon the archbishop thanked him for making the writ. This man was named Hâkon Ulfsson; he was the archbishop's souvenir and had his seal.

339

The archbishop said to him: 'This writ thou shalt seal and hand to Sir Egil, Bishop Laurence' messenger; thou shalt keep it quiet till he is gone from our presence; for we desire to hear and allow no dispeace or prying or party-feuds in a case like this: let this out, and if we come to know it thou shalt lose our friendship, and lose thy place which thou holdest under us.'

340

Hâkon Ulfsson sealed the writ; he was so disloyal to his lord that he showed that open writ ere he brought it to Sir Egil, to one of the chapter there in the manor. That same canon asked the archbishop, Was it true that he had made an end of the Icelandic [Môdruvellir case? The archbishop asked who had told him that; at first he tried to hide it; but afterwards he had to tell the archbishop that Hâkon Ulfsson had shown him the letter. One day the archbishop called his canons together into his public hall, and told them himself the whole

Môdruvellir case; how it had fared with the covenant which Bishop Laurence and the brethren of Modruvellir had made the summer before, according to the plan and first foundation of Bishop Jorund, of excellent memory. And he now declared before the canons, that that settlement ought immutably to stand.

341

‘And we will confirm and ratify the same with our archiéiscopal authority, and will not uphold any other agreement that has been come to over there.’

342

Then the archbishop had read out the writ which he had issued thereon, and all the chapter gave consent to this judgment, together with the archbishop. This done, Sir Egil took hearty leave of Archbishop Eilff, who gave him at parting a fair silver basin and the canon-law book called *Tancred*. Sir Egil left the archbishop’s presence in great state, but Sir Arngrim kept in the background, seeing that the archbishop was utterly resolved that the suit should go in the way now proclaimed. But, for the disloyalty done by Hâkon Ulfsson, the archbishop had him cast into a dungeon, and never after did he keep the said Hâkon by him in any trust.

343

62. South to Bergen went Sir Egil, and lit on a ship trading to Iceland. They had a fair voyage, and reached Eyri safe and sound before St. Laurence’ Day; two nights after St. Laurence’ Day, Sir Egil got home to Hôlar, and Bishop Laurence rejoiced at his coming. And when Sir Egil showed him the writ and decree of the archbishop, and how the Modruvellir suit had gone, he thanked God for it, and likewise Sir Egil for his true and sturdy heed of his master’s business; the archbishop having written how loyally he had done it. Then Bishop Laurence had the writ put from Latin into Norse to be discerned and understood of the people. Much glory Bishop Laurence got from the result of this lawing. Later the writ was read out in the chancel in the sermon, and also before the brethren at Môdruvellir, and was made known abroad

elsewhere. The maligners of Bishop Laurence were very dumb now. Sooth to say, each of the bishops had much to say for his own side of the case. Lord John wished that the laws should be kept; for the laws and rules of St. Augustine really are that the brethren should control secular things without the walls even as within they control the conduct and discipline; and that it is unseemly for them to be almsmen of laics; as Lord Bishop John himself bore witness at Môdruvellir, and as is told above in the history. “Whereas Bishop Laurence wished to hold by the state things were in when Bishop Jorund first founded the monastery. Therefore they who hear this history must not blame or blemish either of the aforesaid bishops in this matter, for each most likely thought he was upholding the just cause. Nor was the way in which the archbishop chose to judge this case any discredit to Bishop John in the end. Never again could Bishops John and Laurence have the old cordiality, but Bishop John showed high displeasure at the way the archbishop had dealt with the Môdruvellir case. Bishop Laurence now took unto him the whole power at Modruvellir, appointing them an overseer, and dealing with the brethren in all ways according to the bidding and ordinance of Bishop Jorund when he founded the monastery. But the yeoman who had meddled with the brethren, the bishop proclaimed under ban; namely Uppsala-Hrolf. The tenor of the charges made by those who passed between the Bishop and Hrolf was this: — the bishop was told that Hrolf had made with the priest Klaeng Hjaltason a privy bargain for Klaeng’s wife Arnbjdrg. This was not clearly proven, but witness was alleged to be forthcoming that Klaeng had taken Hrolfs money. It happened later that the bishop brought many charges against Hrolf and put him out of the church. Hrolf stayed under this ban till Bishop Laurence died. Bishop Laurence wished to keep the laws of Holy Church, with whomsoever he had to deal. But he also looked narrowly to penances, as might be shown from a thing that befell in his days. A cleric, consecrated sub-deacon, born in Fnjdsk-Dale, went to the East Firths, and came into the district of Fljdts-Dale, and so to Valthjdfstad. And when he had come there he was

so puffed up with great wickedness and monstrous foolhardiness, that he gave himself out for a mass-deacon and asked to read the gospel at mass. A stole was brought him, and when he began to read the gospels, all the lights went out in the church, and as often as the people there tried to light them, it was just as if a blast came on them. The deacon's lesson went on, but the lights could not be kindled; this seemed a strange thing to the people there, but at first they suspected nought from it. Also he betook himself to another church to read the gospel, and all went as at Valthjof's church; all the lights went out and could not be kindled. A suspicion now sprang up that he was only consecrated a subdeacon, and not a mass-deacon. This was told to Bishop John; then he told his provost to make the man go, little as he might like it, west to Holar. This was done, and the man owned that he had twice publicly read the gospel in mass. It seemed to Lord Bishop Laurence that the case appertained to Bishop John, because the man had sinned in John's diocese. So he sent the deacon south to John and two men with him that he might not give them the slip anywhere. Then Bishop John sent a letter by him north to Bishop Laurence, giving him authority by letters-patent to set the man a fitting penance and absolve him. This, among other things, was the penance the bishop set him; six mass-deacons were each to whip him on the bare back so smartly that the blood came. For the bishop proclaimed that with unheard-of presumption he had intruded into the deacon's office; and therefore it was right for him to be smitten by deacons, whose office he took upon him without holy ordination. Then he absolved the cleric, telling him that he should never be legally ordained unless the pope gave him dispensation. Also it came about that this deacon got the name of "Gadding" Arni.

344

In the year when these things happened, sad news came of a fire at Christ Church in Nidaros of all the woodwork; and the wall split in many places, the bells were destroyed and many treasures besides. The

archbishops wrote of this mishap to the bishops in Iceland. An offering was asked for the church over all the country, and much money given.

345

63. At this time Bishop Laurence employed a goldsmith called Eyjdlf, a good craftsman. Bishop Laurence made him work two very splendid gospel books for the church at Holar, which can yet be seen there; also a goodly chalice.

346

1329 Sept 29

347

The bishop got angry with him for the high wages of his smith's work; they seemed more than their worth. The bishop bargained with the goldsmith that he should come back in the autumn on Michaelmas day, and work Laurence's shrine there through the winter.

348

June 17

349

In the spring, close on St. Botolph's Eve, a ship from Norway touched at Gâseyri, and over this ship was Berg Jônsson, the archbishop's steward. The ship came from Throndhjem. The said Berg came to Holar and brought Bishop Laurence a very goodly mitre which Lord Archbishop Eilff sent him, and two boxes therewith holding balsam: this mitre is now the best at Holar. Such a thing showed what affection the archbishop bore to him. In recompence for this he gave thirty bales of wadmal, and asked Berg to stay the winter at Holar, which he accepted. In winter Bishop Laurence visited over the western district. He was at Kûla at the wedding feast of John and Ingigerd, and most of the great men in Iceland were there. Lord Bishop Laurence preached there, and his loving yet devout way of discourse was the admiration of many discerning people.

350

Oct 13

351

On Michaelmas Day there was a spell of frost and snow, and Bishop Laurence said that he was sure the winter would be hard. Then he came to Holar on the Feast of Relics.

352

Jan 13, 1330

353

Then it came to pass that Hallbera, abbess at Stad, died. Bishop Laurence was then summoned, and sent word that he would come to the sisters after Yule, nigh on Epiphany; as was done. Then Sister Gudny, daughter of Helgi, was chosen abbess, but was only consecrated by Bishop Egil, successor of Bishop Laurence.

354

64. This winter was most bitter weather. There was scant hay and much live stock in the church farm.

355

1329-30

356

Bishop Laurence had written home to Steward Sküli that he was to kill a good deal, for he said at Michaelmas that he thought the winter would be hard. Sküli complied not with the bishop's words, and had no greater a killing than common. In winter came the time for the ewes to be in heat, but the earth was snowbound. The bishop admonished Sküli to slaughter the cattle; for it was now reported that the stock of the church was without food. Sküli took little heed of the bishop's words, and fewer were slain than ever.

357

After Yule brother Arni took a great sickness, and was down a long time through the winter.

358

1331

359

Great searchings of heart had Lord Bishop Laurence because of his shocking way of life, all in the teeth of cloister discipline.

360

March 3

361

In the winter on the day of the translation of Bishop John, it came to pass, that great pains troubled him; and as soon as Bishop Laurence prayed over brother Arni, he mended.

362

Once in Lent the bishop came to him, and spoke very sternly to him, admonishing him to repent of his courses, and saying thus: 'If thou wilt vow to God and to me that thou wilt go straightway back to the monastery at Thingeyri, when thou lovest me, then I will dare — though thou deserve it not — to pray God for thee that thou mend of this sickness. For in the monastery at Thingeyri thou canst live very cleanly, canst teach and write. But if it is in thy mind to break this our bidding, and to go to Norway when thou lovest us, then thy counsel cannot thrive, for we know that thou wilt fall to swilling and other iniquity, and then Holy Church gets no good of thy parts.'

363

The bishop ceased not till Arni was touched and wept bitterly, promising to go back to Thingeyri and abide there, as soon as he lost the bishop. "Which promise of his was kept less than beseemed him; for his course of life was even as his father foretold. The weather began to worsen, and times continued to be hard; at last the sheep dropped down for leanness like drifting waves. It had been better to follow the will of Bishop Laurence and slay them while there was flesh on them, than that no man should have good of them. Laurence was a man of such foresight that much went according as he foretold.

364

March 19

365

65. On the eve of the Annunciation of the Blessed Virgin Mary, when Bishop Laurence was thinking of going to evensong, he felt heavy and ill just as the bell was going, and said to his close friend, Deacon Einar Haflidason, that he could not go out to evensong, but begged him to go and chant, some of the clergy being ill. This sickness which Lord Laurence then took, grew on him from day to day, so that he ate well nigh nothing, which was a drain upon his strength. Yet he went every day to High Mass, leaning upon Deacon Einar. Lady Day was that year the Monday in the last week of Lent. Ill as he was, he never broke his dry fast.

366

March 31

367

On Easter Day he was at offices, sitting in his seat; had mass said to him in the vestry, and received the Lord's Body. Through the day he did not sit indoors with the priests. But at evening he grew worse. And when the rest were gone to sleep, he roamed about the timber hall, and got himself upon the dais. He sent Deacon Einar out to see where the star had reached, and when the deacon came back, the bishop said to him:

368

'Friend, I dreamed a dream. I thought I was lying on the dais, and I held up my right hand.

369

And methought I had in my hand the bone of a saint; it was a long bone, and I thought I would have that bone kept in St. Laurence's shrine.'

370

Now the bishop had made Eyjolf the goldsmith make in the winter that shrine which now may be seen above the high altar at Holar.

371

Deacon Einar answered: 'This is a perfect dream and a devout.'

372

The bishop answered: 'In my hand, there, I had a hard feeling, for the bone is hard; and that will be a token of my sickness.'

373

Next day, in Easter week, he went very ill into his study, sat in his chair, and bade Deacon Einar drag out a great chest, giving him the key to open it.

374

1331, April 1

375

The bishop himself had the key to this chest, the deacon having keys to all others in the wardrobe. Him he bade take up everything from the chest and lay it out on the floor. Then the deacon counted out fifty pence, two rosaries of silver, weighing thirty-seven marks, twenty-three silver spoons, five brooches and three locketts, some old, broken silver, and a few English pennies. These weighed twenty-six marks and a quarter. Also there were a chalice, a silver belt, three girdles, and tablets of walrus tusk. Besides, he took out of a box ten gold rings, having summoned Skuli the steward.

376

Then said the bishop to him and the deacon: 'Here may ye see what things I have got and gathered for the church here at Holar since I have been bishop. To this have gone my bishop's tithes. Some of these I have bought; some, good friends of mine have given me, and I have gathered what I thought would best suit the church.'

377

Then answered Skuli: 'The church would seem to me to want meat and live beasts more than these.'

378

'Say not so, Skuli,' said the deacon, 'nothing can be more precious or needful to the church than gold or refined silver, for with this refined silver and gold the bishop can have many a blessed thing wrought to deck the church withal, if he will have a shrine or altar-piece made over the high altar.'

379

Then the bishop spoke: 'What you two were heard to say just now came verily from your wisdom. Thou, Sküli, hast not looked well after the live stock of the church, so that they have starved and perished, and there is no use of them. But this which you see now perishes not unless it be wasted of men.'

380

Then the bishop bade them put the things back as before. Sir Laurence sent a man west to Breidabolstad to Sir Thorstein with a letter bidding him come north with all speed. Another letter was sent to Grenjadarstad to Sir Egil, bidding him come to Holar as swiftly as he might. Sir Thorstein came on the Sunday after Easter, and the bishop rejoiced much at him.

381

April 7, April 8

382

On Monday the bishop announced to Sir Thorstein that he wished to make his will and all his dispositions; saying he foresaw that he would depart because of this sickness. Then he told how he disposed about himself. Sir Egil was not yet come. Sir Thorstein Illugason he made his Official and vicar in spiritual things till another bishop came to look after them. The clergy then staying on the foundation were to have their table there till another bishop came. There were also other such elsewhere, which made eight or nine poor clergy whom he had taken from poverty and beggary and had taught the psalter and chanting and Latin, so that then they were as good priests as the rest. To the church of Thingeyri and to Múnka-Thverà he made a gift, twelve hundred to each monastery, and likewise twelve hundred to the brethren at Modruvellir for their comfort. Also all the almsmen were to stay on the foundation and in its outlying parts till another bishop came. To Sir Thorstein he gave twenty yards of cloth, twelve hundred worth of stuff, and a goodly gold ring; to each of the choir priests a

goodly gown. To Steward Skuli he gave fifteen yards of cloth and a coat.

383

To Deacon Einar he thus spoke: 'Our parting is now other than I had meant; for I had meant to consecrate thee priest and give thee some such rich benefice as thou deservest. As it is, we will give thee, for thy comfort, and in return for thy loyal and trusty service to us, a whole suit of cloth, two tabard-kirtles with a hood. For this shalt thou measure out of the wardrobe thirty ells of linen, also thou shalt have whatever pillow for thy head thou choosest, and a pair of shoes. Thou deservest better for thy trusty service to us, and we bid you, Sir Thorstein, my friend, to send him south to Skálholt and have him consecrated by Bishop John, so that he be hereafter choir priest here at home till a bishop come. He has been my one pupil who has never done aught against me while he has been in my service.'

384

To everybody at the church he gave some keepsake: to each of the deacons six ells of linen: to Solvi, the house-steward, six hundred; to Gudrun, the stewardess, eight yards of red cloth and a psalter, to Thorir Isleifson, the guestman, a hundred and twenty; to Sigurd, the cook, a mortgage, north in Myrk-Water. Brother Arni, his son, he appointed to go back to his monastery at Thingeyri, sending a letter by him to Abbot Gudmund to say what he bequeathed to the monastery of the treasure which he had: this was nearly eighteen hundred, and his clothes and books to boot.

385

April 9

386

All this was done on the Monday; on the Tuesday he made his confession to Sir Thorstein. Then were called all the clerks and those of the servants at the church who cared to attend. Sir Thorstein gave him extreme unction, and before he was anointed the bishop spoke again, declaring, concerning the people he had put under the ban,

namely Uppsala-Hrolf and his train, that they should so remain till another bishop arrived; unless they were to swear to stand to the judgment of Holy Church, in which case the Official was to absolve them. After this speech of the bishop he was anointed: and when the body of God was brought to him he made a discourse so long and beautiful that many who were there wept, and himself most. Now on Tuesday, when, as we have said, the unction was over, his strength sank and sank; nevertheless he read his offices, and ever through his illness he had read unto him the *Expositions* of St. Gregory the pope and the prayers of Augustine; and while he was ill, he wept so sorely, especially when such things were read before him, that the tears were never dry on his cheeks.

387

April 12

388

On Friday in that week Sir Egil came to Holar, and when he and the bishop met the bishop rose up in his bed to receive him and embraced him with joy. Then they spoke together of many things known to none else.

389

The bishop showed him how he had appointed all things, and Sir Egil thought it wise in every jot. On Saturday the bishop bade Deacon Einar bring into the wooden hall — for he was lying there — some very fair tapestries and two flagons wrought precious.

390

Then said the bishop to Sir Egil: ‘These tapestries, Sir Egil, we will give thee, and likewise these flagons wherewith thou mayest deck thy room fairly; also we will give thee our gold ring which we have had wrought and have worn, and there is in it a holy relic of a bone of the sainted John, Bishop of Hôlar.

391

Then he took that same ring from his finger and handed it to him; and as soon as Sir Egil had thought to keep the ring, then the bishop

snatched the ring from him, saying: 'Thou shalt not get the ring till I am dead; thou wilt keep me more in mind afterwards.'

392

It was done even as he said. Then said the bishop to Sir Egil that he would send him that summer to Norway to the archbishop, with that tidings about his death, which he said he knew would quickly come to pass. Then were the letters written which were to go on to the archbishop, wherein Lord Laurence declared that it would better serve the church, both lay and learned, in Holar see to have an Icelander for a bishop than a Norwegian; for he would know the character of the people better. In all ways the bishop prepared for his departure like one that was whole; but all could see how his strength faded. At...

393

[Here ends the Manuscript; and the end of the history for the three last days of Laurence' life is lacking, for he died on the 16th of April. For his last day Einar's Annals say]

394

April 16, 1331

395

On the last day of his life he bade Sir Egil and Deacon Einar read in his hearing the offices of the Holy Ghost, and when they were read he thus spoke: 'Ye twain are both my disciples, and therefore I entreat you to keep these offices hereafter every day.'

396

Then brother Arni read mass, and the bishop made all his due responses in the Mass, and after Mass, when the blessing was given upon those who stood by, he yielded up his soul to God, as I should truly trust. Also Sir Thorstein Illugason bore witness that he had never been by any man who had departed so wonderfully from the world as Lord Bishop Laurence.